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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: PM'S SECRETARIAT

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' and other leaders of the ruling alliance participating in a meeting held at the PM's official residence, Baluwatar in Kathmandu on Saturday.

Overdependence on remittance not in long-term interest of country

BY LAXMAN KAFLE
Kathmandu, Jan. 6

Nepal has been receiving more than Rs. 100 billion remittances a month for the past couple of months. With the improvement in remittance inflow, the indicators of the external and internal sector of the economy are also improving.

For the past few months, an increase has been witnessed in foreign currency reserves, balance of payment, current account and remittance inflows. In the meantime, the gradual decline in bank interest rate and available liquidity in the banking sector has created a ray of hope that the country's economy has become viable.

At a time when the country's productivity has not increased to the desired level and the government is unable to collect revenue even to meet the recurrent expenditure, significant increment in remittance inflows has given a new lease of life to the national economy.

Information Officer of Nepal Rastra Bank Dr. Dilli Ram Pokhrel said that the remittances sent by the workers who have gone abroad for employment have contributed significantly to the foreign currency reserves, putting the balance of payments and current account in surplus.

According to the NRB, Nepal received Rs. 477.96 billion remittance during the first four months of the current fiscal year.

The gross foreign exchange reserves increased by 10.2 per cent to Rs. 1,696.78 billion in mid-November 2023 from Rs. 1539.36 billion in mid-July 2023.

The foreign exchange reserves of the banking sector are sufficient to cover the prospective merchandise imports of 13.6 months, and merchandise and services imports of 11.3 months.

"With the increase in remittance inflows, the liquidity in the banking sector has improved and the interest rates have come down. Therefore, remittances have had a positive impact on the national economy," Dr. Pokhrel told *The Rising Nepal*.

TRN SPECIAL

However, to make the national economy independent, the country should not be overly dependent on remittances for a long time, he added.

If the remittance money is not spent for import, it will ease liquidity in the market and support to invest in the productive sector, said former finance secretary Rameshore Khanal.

"At present, the increased remittance inflow has supported in easing liquidity to lending in the productive sector which helps in employment generation and production. When employment generation increases, people who have been abroad for employment will be encouraged to return to the country," he said.

Record high remittance

According to the latest report of NRB, Nepal has received remittance of Rs. 477.96 billion in the first four months of the current fiscal year 2023/24. This is 26.4 per cent higher than the remittance received in the same period last fiscal year.

In the US dollar terms, remittance inflows increased by 23.1 per cent to 3.60 billion in the review period compared to an increase of 10.8 per cent in the same period of the previous year.

The country received Rs. 112.62 billion in the month of Kartik (mid-October to mid-November 2023).

However, Nepal received record high remittance of around Rs. 137 billion in a single month of Ashoj (from September 18 to October 17). The country received remittance around Rs. 116.09 billion in the month of September.

The inflow of remittances in the past 10 years has increased except during the global COVID-19 pandemic in the fiscal year 2019/20.

In the fiscal year 2013/14, Nepal received remittance of Rs. 543.29 billion, while in the fiscal year 2022/23 it reached Rs. 1,220.55 billion. The country received remittance of Rs. 961.05 billion in the fiscal year 2020/21 and Rs. 1,007.3 billion in the fiscal year 2021/22 billion.

Over the past 10 years, average annual growth of remittance inflows has been 11.13 per cent.

"The growing use of digitalisation, increasing trend of sending remittance through the formal channels and increasing number of migrant workers are the main reasons behind the increase in remittance inflows in the country," said Dr. Pokhrel.

The foreign workers are sending money to Nepal when the dollar has strengthened, which also contributed to the increase in remittance inflow, he said.

Growing dependence on remittance

Remittances play an important role as a financial source to offset the gradually increasing trade deficit of Nepal. The remittance income under the

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NA election

Ruling parties agree on seats allocation

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 6

Ruling political parties on Saturday agreed on allocation of candidacies for National Assembly (NA) elections to be held on January 25. However, the parties agreed to sit again on Sunday to finalise the candidacies to be shared among them.

"Out of 19 vacant seats of the NA, Nepali Congress will file candidacy on10 seats, CPN-MC on six, CPN (Unified Socialist) on two and Janata Samajbadi Party on one," said Barshaman Pun Ananta, Deputy General Secretary of the CPN-MC.

Earlier, a meeting of the ruling parties held on Saturday afternoon took decision to allocate candidacies for the 19 NA seats among themselves.

Discussion was held among top leaders of the ruling alliance at the official residence of the Prime Minister, Baluwatar, thereby agreeing to reach conclusion on seat allocation among the ruling parties, said NC leader Ramesh Lekhak.

Discussion was also held on the issue of coordinating with the main opposition party, CPN (UML), shared leader Lekhak.

However, the CPN (UML) has announced to file candidacies in all vacant posts in the NA elections. After the UML's announcement, an agreement was reached among the alliance parties to go for NA election, allocating seats among the alliance parties, he explained.

"Although discussion was held to take together the opposition parties in NA Assembly as a broader democratic practice, it was not possible for the time being', he said.

"Meanwhile, the meeting held Saturday evening concluded without making final decision about seat allocation among ruling political parties. The party leaders concluded to continue efforts to forge consensus on NA seats," leader of CPN (Unified Socialist) said talking to journalists.

Prime Minister and CPN (Maoist Centre) Chair, Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda', NC President Sher Bahadur Deuba, and CPN (Unified Socialist) Chair Madhav Kumar Nepal, as well as other top leaders were present in the meeting. The NA election is taking place on January 25.

Govt forms probe panel to investigate Sah's death

Victim's family to get Rs. 1 million relief

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 6

The government has decided to provide Rs. 1 million as relief to the family of Jaishankar Sah, who died in a clash during the demonstration at Barathawa in Sarlahi on Friday.

Issuing a press note on Saturday afternoon, the Ministry of Home Affairs has decided to provide the relief amount to the family of Sah, who died in the incident.

In addition, it is mentioned in the statement that a three-member investigation committee under the coordination of Joint Secretary Thaneshwar Gautam of the Home Ministry, has been formed to investigate the facts about the incident and submit a report within seven days.

On Friday, 30-year-old Sah was shot dead by the police during a demonstration on whether or not to upgrade the primary health centre in Barathawa Municipality-5.

Deputy Inspector General of Police (DIG) Surendra Mainali and Director of Investigation of National Investigation Department Bhim Bahadur Budhathoki are members of the investigation committee.

On Friday, 30-year-old Sah was shot dead by the police during a demonstration on whether or not to upgrade the primary health centre in Barathawa Municipality-5.

'Crisis in economy is not over'

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Chitwan, Jan. 6

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat has said that the government will spend only in the areas where the investments bring returns.

Speaking at the 57th General Meeting and Convention of Chamber of Commerce and Industry, Chitwan on Saturday, he said said that the government had a focus on enhancing production.

"We will create an environment conducive to do business in the manufacturing industry. There are many opportunities in this sector. Likewise, the government has a plan to promote investment and entreprises in tourism and Information Technology as well," he said.

Finance Minister Dr. Mahat said that the economy has started to recover. Stating that the statistics have shown a significant recover in the economy, he said that those who are wishing to leave the country on the pretext of bad economic shape should know this fact.

"I request you not to follow rumours and propaganda, on social media. Upcoming days will be very good and the economy will show it," he maintained.

However, he stated that the country's economy was in trouble and there is still a lot to be done. "Crisis is not over, the price increase is on the decline and one should recognise the fact. However, industries are still in trouble," said FM Dr. Mahat. He also said that those who invested in land and stock market during the COVID-19 pandemic have witnessed a heavy loss.

According to him, then there was a problem due to excessive borrowing and the introduction of tight monetary policy.

He said that the government would pay the dues to the contractors by mid-February while the government was planning to increase the capital expenditure.

Speaking at the programme, the president of the Federation of Nepalse Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FNCCI), Chandra Prasad Dhakal said that the interest rate of bank loans was decreasing. Expressing his happiness that the economy is about to return to normal, he said that all should think positively.

Breach of lane rule nullifies Naya Baneshwor's upgraded intersection

BY NAYAK PAUDEL
Kathmandu, Jan. 6

Naya Baneshwor is one of the major intersections in the Kathmandu Valley which has recently received a facelift to introduce an urban transport management system.

The changes were made as a part of a pilot project for intersection improvement in the Kathmandu Valley under the coordination of the Government of Nepal and the Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA).

Of the facelift, the major change includes the construction of a divider in the Naya Baneshwor Chowk for vehicles plying the main lanes of the eight-lane Maitighar-Tinkune Highway.

The divider, around 200 metres in length, has been erected on two sides of the intersection by covering an extra lane dedicated to the opposite traffic on the main lane.

According to the concerned stakeholders, a lane for the opposite



traffic was encroached to extend space for vehicles in need of a right turn.

The Kathmandu Valley Traffic Police Office informed that it was a good step to minimise traffic congestion at the Naya Baneshwor Chowk, but it would prove beneficial only when the commuters followed lane discipline.

Traffic police officers deployed at the Naya Baneshwor Chowk informed that lack of lane discipline had prevented vehicles from heading right in their turns due to the divider.

Earlier, when there were no dividers, vehicles waiting to either turn towards Purano Baneshwor (a right turn while heading west) or Sankhamul (a right turn while heading east) on the main lanes would cover the lanes for opposite traffic on the right when their turns came.

"I remember not getting space on the lane dedicated for vehicles taking a right turn in Naya Baneshwor in June 2023. When the light turned green for a right turn, I would follow other vehicles as they head forward covering the remaining two lanes for the opposite traffic," said Kamal Raj Karki, a businessman from Morang district who was stuck on the right lane as he was headed towards Sankhamul on Thursday evening.

However, the convenience has now ended because of the divider.

While authorities say that an extra lane has been encroached to create space for right-turning vehicles, the lane is often occupied by vehicles heading straight during peak hours.

"This time, the divider prevented any vehicle from occupying the opposite lane, and vehicles heading straight restricted us from using the lane dedicated for right-turners. The intersection was only 150 metres away, but I was able to take a right turn only after the traffic light for a right turn turned green for the third time," Karki stressed.

While a concrete divider has been erected on the main lanes, orange-coloured metal rods have been installed before the intersection from the Purano Baneshwor side.

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Customs discount on EVs is meant mainly for consumers: Minister Mahat

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 6

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat has said that the tax discount given on electric vehicles should also be transferred to the consumers.

Addressing the 47th Annual General Meeting of NADA Automobiles Association of Nepal on Friday evening, Finance Minister Mahat noted that the government has given tax concession for the promotion of EVs, so the concession should be transferred to the consumers.

"The government has given concessions to the people as well, not only to businessmen. It seems that a situation has been created where the businessmen do not give cars to customers at the same exemption rate."

Minister Mahat said that there is a lot of loss in revenue now owing to providing concessions on customs for the import of electric vehicles. He, however, said that the growing use of electric vehicles is also reducing the import of petroleum products and supporting efforts to make the environment clean and reduce trade deficit.

Stating that the government will emphasise on expansion of charging infrastructure for electric vehicles, Minister Mahat urged NADA itself to invest in charging infrastructure.

He said that the automobile sector was expanding and assembly factories were opening and parts and other materials were being made, which is a matter of happiness. Finance Minister Dr. Mahat said that the problems seen in the country's economy are gradually going away.

Stating that the country's economy has gradually returned to its own track compared to the past, he said that there is a need for starting positive discourse to make the economy more viable and stronger by enhancing public confidence.



PHOTO: TRN
Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat presenting honouring auto entrepreneurs in Kathmandu on Saturday.

On the occasion, President of Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry Chandra Dhakal said that disputes of dedicated and trunk line arrears should be solved at the earliest.

"If our existing authorities, including the Electricity Authority, Electricity Regulatory Commission, Ministry of Energy and any other agencies are ready to solve this problem, let's solve it. If not, let's solve it by forming a judicial commission," he said.

Dhakal said that there would be adverse impact on economy and employment creation if the dispute between the NEA and businesses lingered longer.

Stating that the businessmen are in a very difficult situation, he said that as the indicators of the economy are improving lately the government should create a positive situation.

President of Confederation of Nepalese Industries (CNI) Rajesh Kumar Agrawal stressed on the need for creating a business-friendly environment by amending the existing policies and laws related to business and investment. President of Nepal Chambers of Commerce Rajendra Malla suggested that the government should expand the tax net instead of increasing tax rates to increase revenue.

Outgoing President of NADA Automobile Association of Nepal Dhruba Thapa said that businessmen are discouraged by the rumours of tax rates changes on electric vehicles in next year's budget.

He urged the government to maintain stability in personal taxes and not to increase taxes by giving high priority to electric vehicles.

He said that when the tax on electric vehicles is increased frequently in Nepal, there is a situation where investment in the ecosystem is discouraged.

Stating that the government has treated vehicles as a luxury but now it has become essential, he said that the government should reduce customs on vehicles.

He said that the government should not look at the automobile sector as an unproductive sector, saying that the transport sector has contributed greatly to the collection of customs revenue and has been providing employment to tens of thousands of people directly and indirectly.

"In the automobile sector, there is more than Rs. 100 billion investment. Therefore, it is necessary for the government to arrange a stable policy and facilitate for its expansion," he said.

Karan Chaudhary has been elected unopposed as the president of NADA Automobiles Association of Nepal.

The 47th Annual General Meeting of NADA Automobiles Association of Nepal has elected a new executive committee under Chaudhary's chairmanship.

Possibility of tea cultivation in Karnali discussed



RSS
Karnali, Jan. 6

A provincial level discussion was held on the feasibility of tea and coffee farming in Karnali. The discussion in Birendranagar on Friday was organized by the National Tea and Coffee Development Board in coordination with Siddhartha Multipurpose Cooperatives Limited Surkhet.

Speaking at the programme, Minister of Land Management, Agriculture and Cooperatives of Karnali, Bhim Prakash Sharma, said that there is great potential for tea and coffee cultivation in Karnali and requested the Board to provide technical human resources for the same.

Members of the Karnali Provincial Assembly, Bindaman Bista and Ghanashyam Bhandari, expressed displeasure that tea and coffee farming was not promoted in Karnali like in other provinces.

Mohan Kumar Acharya, a coffee farmer from Barahtal Rural Municipality-3, Surkhet, said that due to lack of technical knowledge the coffee plants had to be removed while the harvested coffee could not be sold.

Executive Director of the Board, Dr. Bishnu Prasad Bhattarai, said that there is great potential for tea and coffee in Karnali and called for coordination and cooperation between the provincial and federal governments under the leadership of all local levels for making it a reality.

Chief of Tea and Coffee Development Board Office in Pyuthan, CP Basnet, shared that Salyan, Rukum Paschim, Jajarkot, Dailekh and Surkhet districts in the province are suitable for tea and coffee farming.

Secretary of Siddhartha Multi-Purpose Cooperatives Limited, Tularam Sinjali, said the cooperatives has been purchasing the produce of tea and coffee farmers in the province, so that it does not go waste.



PHOTO: KAVIN ADHIKARI\TRN
As Maghe Sankranti, an important Nepali festival of harvest approaches, traders are busy selling yams at the Kalimati vegetable market in Kathmandu.

Lamjung witnesses decline in orange production

RSS
Lamjung, Jan. 6

Production of orange has decreased in Lamjung. The decrease in orange production has been attributed to disease in the orange plants as well as lack of sufficient care of the orange orchards.

Orange production has been decreasing for some years in Syaut village, which is listed as a pocket area by the District Agricultural Development Office. Until a decade ago, farmers earned an annual income of up to Rs 20 million from orange orchards across the village.

Farmers have said that there has been a decrease in production even in high-productivity areas such as Chiti, Gaonsahar, Simpani, Bhorletar, Kuncha, Gahte, Duradanda, Rainas, Bhoje, Udipur.

Bhagwati Pant of Syaut in Benisahar Municipality-11 has planted more than 600 orange trees on 13 ropani of land. A decade ago, she was earning Rs 600,000 to Rs 700,000 per year. But in recent years, she barely earns Rs 80,000.

Information officer of Agriculture Knowledge Centre, Bijay Paudel, said 400 metric tons of oranges have been produced in the current fiscal year 2080-81 from the orange plantations in an area of 130 hectares in the district. In the last fiscal year, 525 metric tons of oranges were produced in 125 hectares of land in the district. Hence, although the area under orange cultivation has increased the production has decreased by 125 metric tons.



According to the Center, there has been a decrease in the production due to various diseases, insects and lack of sufficient attention of the farmers during the production stages of orange. Orange farmers not paying attention to work such as pruning, regular care, irrigation, and plant selection, orange orchards are disappearing.

PepsiCo products are being pulled from stores in Europe

AP
Paris, Jan. 6

Global supermarket chain Carrefour will stop selling PepsiCo products in its stores in France, Belgium, Spain and Italy over price increases for popular items like Lay's potato chips, Quaker Oats, Lipton Iced Tea and its namesake soda.

The French grocery chain said it pulled PepsiCo products from shelves in France on Thursday and added small signs in stores that say, "We no longer sell this brand due to unacceptable price increases."

It comes as a new French law meant to fight the rising cost of living has supermarkets facing millions in fines if they don't reach a deal with suppliers on prices by the end of the month.

The ban also will extend to Belgium, Spain and Italy, but Carrefour, which has 12,225 stores in more than 30 countries, didn't say when it would take effect in those countries.

PepsiCo products were still on shelves Friday in Rome and Barcelona. Carrefour Italia's press office said information will be posted for customers in their stores in Italy in the next days.

PepsiCo said in a statement that it has "been in discussion with Carrefour for many months and we will continue to engage in good faith in order to try to ensure that our products are available."

The company behind Cheetos, Mountain Dew and Rice-A-Roni has raised prices by double-digit percentages for seven straight quarters, most recently hiking by 11% in the July-to-September period.

Its profits are up, though higher prices have dragged down sales as people trade down to cheaper brands. PepsiCo also has said it's been shrinking package sizes to meet consumer demand for convenience and portion control.

"I do think that we see the consumer right now being more selective," PepsiCo Chief Financial Officer Hugh Johnston told investors in October.

The Purchase, New York-based company said price increases should ease and largely align with inflation, which has fallen considerably worldwide since crunched supply chains during the COVID-19 pandemic and then Russia's war in Ukraine sent prices surging.

However, the 20 European Union countries that use the euro currency saw consumer prices rise to 2.9% in December from a year earlier, rebounding after seven straight monthly declines, according to numbers released Friday.

Prices for food and non-alcoholic drinks have eased from a painful 17.5% in the 20-country euro area in March but were still up by 6.9% in November from a year earlier.

The government of French President Emmanuel Macron has fought back on the rising cost of living for households, passing a November law to implement "emergency measures" to fight high prices.

The law moved up annual negotiations between supermarkets and their suppliers on setting prices and more to Jan. 31 from March 1. Fines have been increased to 5 million euros ($5.5 million) for grocery companies that fail to meet the new deadline for setting prices.

Burt Flickinger III, managing director of grocery consultancy Strategic Resource Group, said he thinks PepsiCo was targeted because the company has been one of the most aggressive in raising prices. He thinks other big brand names could be next and that other European retailers could follow Carrefour's lead.

Pulling products off shelves over prices is rare, but it happens. Flickinger noted that Kraft Heinz stopped supplying British retailer Tesco with some of its items in 2022 for a week over a pricing spat.

Rob Dongoski, agribusiness and food lead in the consumer practice of management consultancy Kearney, said the showdown between the two big brands represents the ultimate test of customer loyalty.



PHOTO: KABITA THAPA\TRN
Visitors behold sculptures made by artist Kalu Kumale in his studio in Hattiban, Lalitpur.

Free health camp in Jaleshwar

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Mahottari, Jan. 6

More than 100 patients received services from specialist doctors in a free health camp held in Jaleshwar, the headquarters of Mahottari district on Saturday.

Neuro patients received services in the health camp organised by the Ambika Hospital and Research Centre in the headquarters of Jaleshwar with the support of the Janakpur Neuro Hospital.

Jay Kishore Lal, Director of Ambika Hospital and Research Centre, informed that Dr Vijay Kumar Raut, Consultant Neurosurgeon, Dr Appu Jha, Consultant Physician, Dr Ruvi Singh, Consultant Gynaecologist, and other health workers at the health camp examined the patients.

Lal said that many patients related to neuro disease, migraine, thyroid and obstetric problems have received free health treatment in the camp and free medicines. LY, X-ray, ECG and ultrasound services were also provided in the camp.

Ambika Hospital, which came into operation only about seven months ago, is providing specialist services in Jaleshwar,

"Since I grew up in Jaleshwar, I have obligation towards the people, so I am running the free health camp to provide services to the people," said Lal.

Stating that he had spent two decades at Janakpur Nursing Campus before this, Lal said that he wanted to remove the necessity of travelling to foreign countries for health treatment to the locals and to provide quality treatment at their own village at low cost.



PHOTO: TRN

Patients receiving medical checkup services in a free camp in Jaleshwar on Saturday.

Talking to the media after the camp, Dr Vijay Kumar Raut, Consultant Neurologist, said that most of the patients who came to the health camp were hiding their diseases and suspected that there might be more neuro patients in the area. "There is a need to organize more camps for neuro patients in this area. It is necessary to provide treatment services to all affected people," he added.

Similarly, Dr Appu Jha, consultant physician, said that the number of female patients in the camp was higher and that they were more prone to asthma, pressure, arthritis, and thyroid. He pointed out the need for the local government to work in the field of women's health.

173 residents of Dhanusha deprived of social security allowance

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dhalkebar, Jan. 6

In Dhanusha, 173 residents of Mithila Municipality-9 including senior citizens, single women and Dalit children have not received social security allowance.

Beneficiaries have accused that they were deprived of allowances due to the negligence of Ward Chairman Dipak Jung Thapa, Secretary Ananda Adhikari and office assistant Tul Bahadur Lama.

They claim that the ward office's carelessness led to the loss of documents verifying their eligibility, which were required for submission to the municipality to claim for social security allowance. They had submitted the documents to the ward office in August for renewal.

Drone Kumari Baral, a beneficiary, said that she had submitted photocopies of her citizenship card, photos and the renewal form to office assistant Lama. Similarly, Dhana Maya Pariyar had also submitted all required documents to secretary Adhikari. According to Pariyar, due to negligence of the ward office they had not received two installments of the allowance in the current fiscal year.

Meanwhile, Ward Chair Thapa said that the allowance was not disbursed to those who had failed to renew their social security card. He said that they had informed about the renewal through public announcements, ward's Facebook page and meeting beneficiaries in person. He said, "We have recollected the necessary documents from those who had not renewed and submitted them to the municipality for verification."

Missing ambulances to be searched in Kavrepalanchowk

BY KEDAR TIMALSINA
Banepa, Jan. 6

Ambulances that are not registered or out of contact in the Kavrepalanchowk district will be searched. The District Ambulance Management Committee's meeting held under the coordination of Rudradevi Sharma, Chief District Officer, decided to investigate the condition of ambulances in the district.

The meeting formed a four-member investigation committee to investigate the missing ambulances in the district. According to the committee, the committee members will consist of Methinkot Hospital, Dispatch Centre in Dhulikhel Hospital and the Health Branch of the concerned municipality.

The committee will investigate the category of ambulances operating in the district. It will then prepare an investigation report about the problem of non-standard ambulances and submit it to the District Ambulance Management Committee within three to seven days. In the same meeting, the CDO decided to set a two-month deadline for the operation of ambulances according to the standards of the National Ambulance Directive 2078, section 11. The CDO will also ask the local levels, provincial hospitals, and health institutions to connect the operating ambulances with GPS and operate them according to the upgraded standards.



The CDO said that the meeting also decided to request the Provincial Ambulance Management Committee for the training of ambulance drivers and health workers.

In the meeting, Anita Khanal, Acting Head of the Health Office Kavrepalanchowk, gave information about the condition of ambulances in the district. She said that 39 ambulances have been registered in the district so far, but there is no data about the condition of those ambulances. "It has been found that Dhulikhel Hospital is operating Class A ambulances in the district, but many Class B ambulances are operating at the municipal level," said Khanal.

Dr Sanu Krishna Shrestha, Head of the Emergency Department in Dhulikhel Hospital, gave information about the work of the dispatch centre in Dhulikhel Hospital. Shrestha expressed concern that the integrated ambulance service which started from Kavrepalanchowk has not been operating systematically lately.

The government issued the integrated ambulance and pre-hospital service management guidelines in 2021 and started the ambulance service through the dispatch centre. Following the guidelines of the government, the ambulances of Kavrepalanchowk and Sindhupalchowk are operated through the dispatch centre established in Dhulikhel Hospital, but since the last year, the ambulances of both districts have left the dispatch centre.

After the ambulance is operated through the dispatch centre, the condition of the actual location of the ambulance will be discovered and the driver will not be able to do as they please.

Shrestha said that since the time of Corona, a total of 47 ambulances including 27 from Kavrepalanchowk district and 20 from Sindhupalchowk have been handed over to the dispatch centre.

Landless squatters receive ownership certificates

BY MURARI ADHIKARI
Dhading, Jan. 6

National Land Commission District Committee of Dhading has started distributing certificates to the landless squatters and unmanaged land of Nilkantha Municipality Ward No. 3.

According to Ward Chairman Raj Kumar Shrestha, "Phul Maya Gurung, a resident of Ward Number 3 of Ghimiretar, is handed over a land certificate and 34 others have been given the certificates of unmanaged land.

Earlier, the Committee had distributed certificate to landless Dalits, landless squatters and disorgnaised settlers of Ward No. 2 of Siddalek Rural Municipality.

Krishna Prasad Aryal, coordinator of National Land Commission District Committee of Dhading, said, "No Nepali should be landless, every Nepali has the right to Nepali land,"

Aryal further stressed, "The commission is actively working to identify landless squatters and they will be provided with land certificates allocated by the local government.

Speaking at the certificate distribution programme held at the Rural Municipality Office Ward, Chairman Shrestha said, "This is the first phase of certificate distribution in Nilkantha Municipality-3 and after completing formalities, remaining certificates will also be distributed soon."

The Dhading District Committee was formed with the aims of identifying and providing certificates to landless Dalits, landless squatters and disorganized settlers.

> The Dhading District Committee was formed with the aims of identifying and providing certificates to landless Dalits, landless squatters and disorganized settlers.

Sarita Tamang, member of the committee, said, "The committee is established with the aim of doing identification, documentation and providing land to landless squatters has started doing work in 91 wards out of 104 wards by forming local facilitation committee, and work will be soon started in other wards as well."

The government of Nepal, using the authority under sub-section (3) of section 52 (a) and sub-section (6) of section 52 (b) of the Land Act, 2021, aims to provide land to the landless Dalits and squatters.

According to the Commission, the certificates will be provided after a technician measures and inspects the land, and the facilitation committee investigates the document and sends it to the municipality. After that, it is inspected by the municipality and is sent to the commission.

After completing all this process, within 35 days, the commission starts distributing land certificates to them. The land received in this way can't be sold for 10 years.

KHICHARA FESTIVAL FROM JAN 13

RSS
Chitwan, Jan. 6

A Khichara festival is being organised at Khairahani in Chitwan district to preserve the Tharu culture. The preparations for the ninth Khichara festival to be organised from January 13 have been intensified.

Tharu Welfare Assembly Constituency 7 is organising the event till January 24. Organising a press conference here today, the organiser shared information about the objective and preparation of the festival.

The Khichara festival is going to be held with an objective of preserving and promoting culture, costumes, language, literature and cuisines of Tharu Community on the occasion of Maghi festival.

Maghi is the biggest festival of Tharu community. Kichara festival, which is celebrated on Magh 1 every year, is being organised for the past nine years.

Coordinator of festival main organizing committee, Rameshwor Chaudhary, mentioned that a 200-member main organising committee and 15 different sub-committees were formed to run the festival.

A total of 150 stalls would be kept on display in the festival. Even the competition of agriculture products will feature the event. The organiser expects more than 100 thousand visitors in the festival.

Chinese village transformed by coffee cultivation

BY PRAKASH BIKRAM SHAH
Baoshan (Yunnan, China), Jan. 6

It is hard to believe that a remote village can change in a decade's time. But it has become possible in China's Yunnan province. Xinghai, a mountainous remote village in Yunnan's Longyang district, has become the country's model village after 11 years of efforts.

It takes an hour's bus ride to reach this village near the border of Myanmar (Burma) from the city of Baoshan in Yunnan. "When I arrived 11 years ago, this village was very poor, there were no roads, no electricity, it was far behind in education and social security," said Wang Chiwai, secretary of the Chinese Communist Party in Xinghai village. "Now this village has become accessible, model and green in every way."

Wang, 56, has worked as an architect for 22 years and reached that village with the responsibility of the party. "This village was looking for a leader," he said. I have succeeded in my goal. I am still looking for ways to lead to industrialization."

After Wang came as party secretary, he sent 51 people from the village, which has a population of 4,000 people in 550 households, to study at the university. Being far from road access, this village was also far from the access to education. Now the road has reached. Wang has also made people aware that they should read.

Just as leader Wang tried to make Xinghai village known as a model coffee settlement throughout the country, it is now known as a coffee village. He provided a well-organized road to make the coffee village a model. He made the people agree to commercialize coffee farming. According to that initiative, the annual per capita income of villagers has now increased from 3,000 yuan to over 30,000 yuan.



PHOTO: PRAKASH SHAH/TRN

Chinese Communist Party leader Wang Chiwai and arial view of Baoshan city.

It is said that after the Second World War, the Myanmar army in 1951 imported coffee for the first time to Xinghai. But coffee cultivation started there from 1993. However, since for last 10 years, this village has started to be recognised as a model village for coffee.

With the efforts of Party Secretary Wang, there are now nine groups in four villages of Xinghai. These groups, including tribals and others, cultivate coffee. Those groups plant coffee on 1,600 hectares of this village and produce 4,000 tonnes a year. Seven local cooperative organizations mobilize capital for these villagers.

The residents of Xinghai village, who grow coffee Arabica in particular, sell it and bring in up to 120 million yuan a year. Similarly, 10 million yuan worth of coffee was sold online last year.

After China's National Congress passed six policies including promoting enterprise and empowering the young generation, Secretary Wang is trying to promote Xinghai village as a coffee and agricultural tourism village. So ntourists from China and other countries come to see the development of the village by mean of coffee.

Coffee and seasonal vegetables and fruits are cultivated everywhere on the slopes of Xinghai village, which has high mountains and barren terrain like Nepal. Leader Wang said, "Now, out of four thousand people here, two thousand are in coffee farming. Out of that, 1,000 people are working in coffee farming every day. Three hundred of them are coffee technicians. There are also three hundred electronic engineers in the village," he said.

From the seven cooperatives in this village, coffee distribution and sales have been supported, while the Chinese government is also supporting coffee processing, buying and selling machines. Now the price of coffee has decreased.

The farmers are hoping for an increase in the price of coffee. The government has also been sending local farmers and youth to other provinces to teach them how to cultivate coffee.

"This village was once called precipitous land by the Chinese. Oh, what a village! There are many people who say how it happened," leader Wang shared his experience.

"Now this village is famous as a coffee farm under the hill."

This village, which looks beautiful from the mountain peak, is also crowded with people taking photos. There are homestays with good facilities, so it is easy for the tourists. China's longest river Nuchiang flows a little below Xinghai village. This river from Tibet flows through Myanmar to the Indian Ocean. It is assumed that the tourism activity of the area has increased also because of the river.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Without music, life would be a mistake.
- Friedrich Nietzsche

EDITORIAL

Power Trade Agreement

Hydropower is regarded as one of the major sources of clean energy. As a source of clean energy, it can contribute for cleaner environment and to generate thousands of jobs. It is the only source of energy that Nepal can produce to meet her demand and make a source of foreign earnings. Hydroelectricity is now taken as the most potential commodity that can largely contribute to the national economy in reducing trade deficits through export boosting and import substitutions. Nepal has recently started exporting surplus electricity mostly in monsoon season. Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) has exported electricity worth more than Rs. 15 billion during last monsoon season. The government of Nepal has formulated an Energy Development Strategy with an aim to generate 28,000 MWs electricity in next 12 years. More than half of the electricity generated is expected to be exported in the market of neighbouring countries. For this, the government is making continuous efforts in developing transmission infrastructures and making power trading agreements with neighbouring countries to ensure the market for its surplus electricity generation.

In this regard, there has been a crucial power trade agreement between Nepal and India during the seventh Nepal-India Joint Commission meeting held in Kathmandu. The pact signed on a long-term electricity trade between two countries will enable Nepal to sell about 10,000 Megawatts of electricity to India in a decade. This deal was signed in materialising the Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) signed between the two countries during the visit of Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' to India in May-June last year. Energy secretaries of Nepal and India Gopal Sigdel and Pankaj Agrawal respectively, signed the agreement in the presence of Minister for Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation Shakti Bahadur Basnet. The Joint Commission meeting was co-chaired by Minister for Foreign Affairs, NP Saud and India's Minister for External Affairs, Dr. S Jaishankar.

In addition, an MoU for co-operation in the renewable energy development between Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) and India's NTPC Limited has also been signed during the JC meeting. According to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MoFA), two foreign ministers have jointly inaugurated, in virtual mode, three 132 kV cross-border transmission lines between Nepal and India. Inaugurated transmission lines include: the second circuit of Raxaul-Parwanipur line, the second circuit of Kataiya-Kusaha line, and the New Nautanwa-Mainhiya line. These power infrastructures will facilitate seamless flow of electricity between the two countries. Being the nearest market as well as power-hungry and developing bordering states of Bihar and Uttar Pradesh, India, is the most favourable destination for Nepal in terms of energy trade although discussions are underway also with Bangladesh and China. Bangladesh has been expressing interest to invest in a project worth US$ 1 billion and import electricity from Nepal.

With the current power trading agreement signed with India and completion of the construction of ongoing transmission line between the two countries, it will pave a way for the export of electricity of Nepal to India. In addition to this, it will create a favourable environment for attracting more investments in power sector of Nepal as it guarantees the long-term market for the electricity generated in Nepal. In order to make further progress in the power generation and its export, the government should also take initiative to explore other markets of the region. As Bangladesh has already shown its interest to invest in Nepal's hydropower and importing it, the government should make efforts to materialise it by taking India into confidence. Despite the territorial difficulties, we should focus on developing cross-border transmission line also with China to expand market avenues of its clean energy.

Let's Begin From Beginning

PARMESHWAR DEVKOTA

If the leaders in the government are considered as heroes and side heroes and the construction company owners who do not complete their works in time are considered as villains, then a government can be compared with a cinema incorporating social issues. It is because the film contains almost all the components that the government has. As for an example, the main components of the film are management team headed by a director along with some sub-ordinates. The logistic system is headed by a logistic officer and some helpers. Then, comes the turn of a prominent group of artists as main hero, side-heroes, heroines, villains and supportive staff.

For our ease if you consider the National Planning Commission, Finance Ministry and Nepal Rastra Bank combined as manager and the Prime Minister as the main hero of the country, you can adjust other personalities and institutions accordingly. Additionally, the joint venture construction company owners who take up the responsibility of constructing mega projects, but do not construct them in time or flee away, they must be put in the category of villains.

On the completion of one year in office, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' addressed the nation recently. The address was unique and interesting on three grounds. First, he conceded that they did not produce the desired result in one year as they had targeted before taking to the helm. It may be the first time in the political history of Nepal that an incumbent Premier accepted poor work performance by heart and expressed it in public without blaming anyone for it. In stark contrast to the first point, the Prime Minister accounted a long list of achievements and reformations they made in the second point which can be summarised as: his commitment to dismantling the VIP culture.

He has vowed not to attend programmes unless prior scheduled and appealed to all political parties for formulating a common stand on the foreign affairs issues. His commitment on starting meritocracy in the Tribhuvan University and other universities may change perception of the teachers, students and parents to the universities of the country as the government has initiated procedures for that. Making improvements in the national health insurance system and widening it to the grassroots level by increasing liabilities is another commitment he made.

Giving priority to infrastructure development, he has assured to reform laws, shorten procedural nitty-gritty and end policy level hurdles for it. Barrack concept and two shift work in the infrastructure development projects are worth mentioning.

Including all above things, the Prime Minister, in his speech, has expressed strong commitment on administrative reformation commission on his own chairmanship. It infers that the administrative system of this country is among the main hurdles impeding infrastructure development. The Prime Minister implies that the legal obscurities, procedural delays, among other things, are barriers to steady progress of the country, so, the grudge of the Prime Minister reminds me a cinema which was seen long ago.

In the film, the hero of the film adjusts things scattered around him, only to find things not arranged properly. He arranges them again and again, but things do not go perfectly. Exhausted, the hero says, "Let's begin from the beginning", and starts arranging the things again. The nation making longing of the Prime Minister matches with that of an endeavour of the hero to adjust the things!

AI May Upset Human Life



Gabriel Demombynes

I share the increasingly widespread view that artificial intelligence is going to have huge social and economic consequences. Concretely, how might AI affect human development, particularly in the countries where the World Bank works? AI will help people acquire skills and knowledge. It also has the potential to extend the reach and quality of public services, including for health and social protection. Finally, it is likely to augment human capital and thus amplify productivity for many people, but with difficult-to-predict impacts on jobs and distribution.

AI could yield large gains for learning. My friends who are teachers and even my own French tutor use AI to write lesson plans and quizzes. This application is available now and does not require specialized knowledge or tools. Teachers around the world who have a smartphone can do this with free tools like ChatGPT-3.5. Tutoring by humans has been shown to have a great impact on learning, and AI tools are already competent text — and voice-based interactive tutors. When I tutored, as a volunteer at a local library and as a father at home, I customised my approach to each child's needs. This capability for AI is coming and offers the possibility of delivering individualised tutoring at low cost and on a large scale.

Productivity

AI will also improve access to quality healthcare. The World Bank's Digital-in-Health report identified three areas in which AI is likely to be adopted quickly in healthcare in low-and middle-income countries. AI can pull together and interpret disconnected medical records. It can provide accurate and conversational chatbots as entry points to healthcare. And it can support medical decisions, particularly in radiology, an acutely understaffed specialty in developing countries.

Breast cancer screening, for example, is typically conducted with "double readings" by two different specialists to reduce errors. In a randomised trial, single radiologists assisted by AI detected breast cancer at the same rate as radiologists conducting double readings, reducing workloads by 44 percent. In addition, AI could be a boon for improving mental health — an essential and underappreciated component of human capital — by providing a free or cheap personal therapist in your pocket.

AI can also help to make social protection systems more effective, as demonstrated in a World Bank-supported project in Togo. AI was used there to improve the targeting of a cash transfer programme, to make sure funds were spent on those most in need. Millions of words have been written speculating on the impact of AI on jobs. Like all technology, AI will boost productivity for some tasks, generate new jobs, and replace some jobs altogether. The unprecedented nature of AI makes it impossible to forecast with confidence what lies ahead. That said, because relatively few people in developing countries work in knowledge-intensive jobs, AI's impacts on employment may be more muted than in high-income nations. And how AI may be used in agriculture and traditional sectors remains to be seen.

> To face both AI's opportunities and risks, companies, governments, and international organisations, too, need to prepare themselves to learn and adapt to the coming wave.

AI augments human capital, and in a variety of tasks, it has proved to be an equalising force. One study, for example, found that AI improved the quality and speed of professional writing, with the largest gains for low-ability writers. Similar results have been found for creative writing, legal analysis, and customer support. In other words, if you are a highly talented writer, lawyer, or customer service agent, current AI may not help you much. But if your skills are in the lower half of the distribution, your human capital can now get a powerful assist.

These early results may not hold over the long term and in developing countries' context. Alternatively, AI could end up being an "escalator" – improving the productivity of all workers roughly equally. Or it could be a "kingmaker" – benefiting a small minority of superstars. A key question for developing countries is how to make AI more of an equalising force. Step one is to expand access and affordability of internet connections, which the World Bank is working to do.

Reinventing ourselves

Unfortunately, AI augments the human capital of bad actors as well. This creates myriad risks, including for privacy, cyber security and misinformation. One of the most worrisome scenarios is that AI combined with advances in synthetic biology will make it easier to create new pathogens that could result in an engineered pandemic. The influential thinker Yuval Noah Harari says that because of AI, "for the first time in history nobody has any idea how the world would look like in 10 years", and that consequently "we don't know what skills will be needed. So the most important skill is the skill to keep learning and keep changing throughout our lives, which is very, very difficult.

To keep reinventing ourselves ... Traditionally, people thought about education like building a stone house with very deep foundations. Now it's more like setting up a tent that you can fold and move to the next place very, very quickly. Because that's the 21st century". Harari was talking about individuals, but the same logic applies to institutions. To face both AI's opportunities and risks, companies, governments, and international organisations, too, need to prepare themselves to learn and adapt to the coming wave.

(The author is manager of the Human Capital Project at the World Bank.)
- China Daily

Effect Of Ageing Factor In Sexual Health



Dr. Shyam P Lohani

Sexual health is an integral part of human well-being, and should not be limited to any specific age group. As individuals age, their sexual needs and experiences may change, but this does not diminish the importance of maintaining a healthy and fulfilling sexual life. Significance of age-related sexual health and the need for society to address this often overlooked aspect of overall well-being. Aging together for couples has more benefits than risks and challenges.

As people age, their sexual health needs may alter. Older adults may experience physical changes that affect their sexuality due to erectile dysfunction or vaginal dryness. They may also face a higher risk of sexually transmitted infections (STIs) as the immune system weakens. It is important, however, for individuals of all ages to prioritise their sexual health by practicing safe sex, getting regular STI screenings, and discussing any concerns with their health.

Hormonal factor

As people age, physiological changes occur that can upset sexual health. Age-related changes in physiology cause hormonal fluctuations, blood flow reduction, and the impact of chronic health conditions can all contribute to changes in sexual desire, performance, and ultimately satisfaction. It is crucial to acknowledge these changes and understand care providers.

Sexual health is a lifelong voyage that requires adjustment and support. Society often thinks that older adults are no longer sexually active and, thus, no need to maintain it. This delusion often leads to a lack of discussion and support for age-related sexual health. Breaking the taboo surrounding it is essential to ensure that individuals feel comfortable seeking information, advice, and treatment when needed. Open conversations and continuous education can help oust myths and encourage a more inclusive and supportive environment for sexual health at any age, particularly at older age.

Age-related sexual health is often viewed as an integral part of overall healthy aging. Sexual activity has been linked to numerous physical and mental health benefits, including improved cardiovascular health, reduced stress, and enhanced self-esteem. By promoting sexual health as a component of healthy aging, individuals can be encouraged to prioritise their sexual well-being and seek appropriate care and support.

Age-associated sexual health encompasses a range of concerns that may require attention. These can include addressing issues such as menopause, erectile dysfunction, loss of libido, and the impact of chronic illnesses on sexual function. Healthcare professionals should be equipped with the knowledge and resources to address these concerns and provide appropriate guidance and treatment options.

The importance of emotional connection should not be overlooked. While physical changes occur with age, therefore, emotional aspect of sexual health remains crucial. Emotional closeness, open communication, and maintaining a healthy relationship are vital components of sexual satisfaction in all ages. Encouraging individuals to prioritise emotional connection and fostering healthy relationships can contribute to a fulfilling and satisfying sexual life.

Older adults may also benefit from seeking out resources and support specifically tailored to their sexual health needs. It is also important to recognise that age should not be a barrier to sexual activity or pleasure. Older adults have the right to engage in consensual sexual activity and should not be stigmatised or embarrassed for doing so. Hence, society should work towards creating a more inclusive and accepting attitude towards sexuality and aging.

> Encouraging individuals to prioritise emotional connection and fostering healthy relationships can contribute to a fulfilling and satisfying sexual life.

Moreover, sexual health is important at any age, and oftentimes, older adults are overlooked or neglected in discussions about sexual health owing to the social outlook in their context. As society progresses, the concept of healthy aging has gained significant attention. While physical exercise, balanced nutrition, and mental well-being are often discussed, one crucial aspect that is often overlooked is the role of sex in healthy aging. Contrary to popular belief, sexual activity plays a vital role in maintaining overall well-being and quality of life as individuals age.

Engaging in sexual activity has numerous physical health benefits for older adults. Regular sexual activity can improve cardiovascular health, increase blood circulation, and strengthen the immune system. It also acts as a form of exercise, promoting muscle tone, flexibility, and balance. Additionally, sexual activity releases endorphins, which can alleviate pain, reduce stress, and enhance overall mood. These physical benefits contribute to a healthier, more active lifestyle, ultimately leading to improved longevity.

Sexual activity has a profound impact on mental and emotional well-being, particularly in older adults. It fosters a sense of intimacy, connection, and emotional fulfillment, which can combat feelings of loneliness and depression. Engaging in sexual activity releases hormones like oxytocin and dopamine, which promote feelings of happiness, relaxation, and overall well-being. Moreover, maintaining an active sex life can boost self-esteem, body image, and overall confidence.

Positive impact

Numerous research has suggested that sexual activity can positively impact cognitive function in older adults. Regular sexual activity has been linked to improved memory, increased mental alertness, and enhanced problem-solving skills. The release of hormones during sexual activity stimulates brain activity, promoting neuroplasticity and supporting the growth of new brain cells. This, in turn, can help prevent cognitive decline and age-related conditions such as dementia and Alzheimer's disease.

Even though the benefits of sexual activity in healthy aging are evident, it is essential to acknowledge and address the challenges that may arise. Physical limitations, chronic health conditions, and hormonal changes can affect sexual function and desire. However, open communication, seeking medical advice, and exploring alternative forms of intimacy can help overcome these challenges and maintain a fulfilling sex life.

Hence, age-related sexual health is an important aspect of overall well-being that deserves attention and support. By recognising the impact of aging on sexual health, breaking taboos, promoting healthy aging, addressing specific concerns, and emphasising emotional connection, we can create a society that values and supports sexual well-being at every stage of life. Let us work on this frequently overlooked topic and ensure that individuals of all ages have access to the resources and support they need to maintain a healthy and fulfilling sexual life.

(Dr. Lohani is the executive director at Health Concern, Nepal. lohanis@gmail.com)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 7, 1974

Improved Wheat Cultivation In Surkhet

Surkhet, Jan. 6: In Surkhet district 1038 hectares of land in 19 village panchayats have been brought under improved wheat cultivation under the 'grow more wheat' campaign this year, says RSS.

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READER'S MAIL

Address Crisis Facing Cooperatives

This is in reference to the news story titled *"Cooperatives close, leaving depositors in distress"* published in this daily on Jan. 2. The time has come to shift distress to the cooperative cockroaches, who seem to be doing all they can to embezzle billions of deposits by amassing political and criminal nexus.

The government's reticent on the grave issue is perplexing. What is the government doing to solve the crisis that could explode at least a hundred times more than the recent EPS? Since the cooperatives, like banks, are licensed by the government, it is ultimately responsible for returning the deposits by seizing the properties and assets of the cooperative management.

But before doing so, it can also bring measures to help honest cooperatives tide over genuine problems. Maybe the government can nationalise them, offer them funds, ask banks to buy them out or encourage NRNs, who are always ready to invest in the country, to do so in cooperatives.

If the government does not want to wade into the cooperative problems, it should ask the depositors to retrieve their deposits using means they feel appropriate.

Manohar Shrestha
Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

An engineer, a physicist, and a mathematician are on a train in Scotland.

The engineer looks out the window and sees a black sheep. He comments, "Look, they have black sheep in Scotland". Then physicist looks and comments, "From this observation, we can only say there is at least one black sheep in Scotland."

The mathematician then looks and comments, "Actually, from this we can only say there is at least one sheep in Scotland that's black on one side."

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A woman has twin boys and gives them up for adoption. One goes to a family in Egypt, and is named "Amahl." The other goes to a family in Spain and is named "Juan." Years later, Juan sends a picture of himself to his birth mom. Upon receiving the picture, she tells her husband that she wishes she also had a picture of Amahl. Her husband responds, "But they are identical twins. If you've seen Juan, you've seen Amahl."

Blinken opens urgent Mideast tour in Turkey



PHOTO: AP

U.S. Secretary of State Antony Blinken, left, shakes hands with Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan at Vahdettin, a private residence of the Presidency, in Istanbul, Turkey, Saturday, Jan. 6, 2024.

AP
Istanbul, Jan. 6

U.S. Secretary of State Antony Blinken has kicked off his latest urgent Middle East diplomatic mission in Turkey, as fears mount that Israel's war against Hamas in Gaza may explode into a broader conflict.

Blinken's fourth visit in three months comes amid worrying developments outside of Gaza, including in Lebanon, northern Israel, the Red Sea and Iraq, that have put intense strains on what had been a modestly successful U.S. push to prevent a regional conflagration in the weeks after the war began, and growing international criticism of Israel's military operation.

Blinken was meeting Saturday with Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan and Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan to discuss what Turkey and others can do to exert influence, particularly on Iran and its proxies, to ease soaring tensions, speed up humanitarian aid deliveries to Gaza and begin in earnest to plan for reconstruction and governance of postwar Gaza, much of which has been reduced to rubble by three months of intense Israeli bombardments.

The immediate difficulty of Blinken's task was underscored just hours before his talks with Erdogan as Lebanon's Iran-backed Hezbollah militia fired dozens of rockets at northern Israel, warning that the barrage was just an initial response to the targeted killing, presumably by Israel, of a top leader from the allied Hamas group in Lebanon's capital earlier this week.

Meanwhile, stepped-up attacks on commercial shipping in the Red Sea by Yemen's Iran-backed Houthi rebels have disrupted international trade and led to increased efforts on the part of the U.S. and its allies to patrol the area and respond to threats, including possibly taking direct action against the group at its bases in Yemen. The Houthis have carried out at least two dozen attacks in response to the Israel-Hamas war in Gaza just since Dec. 19, which have further heightened tensions and raised risks for the global economy.

In Istanbul, U.S. officials said Blinken would be seeking Turkish buy-in, or at least consideration, of potential monetary or in-kind contributions to reconstruction efforts and some form of participation in a proposed multi-national force that could operate in or adjacent to the territory. Turkey, and Erdogan in particular, have been harshly critical of Israel and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu for the prosecution of the war and the impact it has had on Palestinian civilians.

In addition, officials said, Blinken will stress the importance the U.S. places on Turkey ratifying Sweden's membership in NATO, a long-delayed process that the Turks have said they will complete soon. Sweden's accession to the alliance is seen as one critical response to Russia's invasion of Ukraine.

From Turkey, Blinken will travel to Turkish rival and fellow NATO ally Greece to meet Prime Minister Kyriakos Mitsotakis at his residence on the Mediterranean island of Crete. Mitsotakis and his government have been supportive of U.S. efforts to prevent the Gaza war from spreading and have signaled their willingness to assist should the situation deteriorate further. Greece has also shown patience in waiting for the delivery of advanced U.S. fighter jets as the issue of Sweden's accession to NATO is worked out with Turkey.

Blinken will end his Saturday in Jordan, which apart from Israel has been the secretary's most frequent stop on his recent Middle East tours. Jordan will be the first Arab nation on Blinken's current tour, and will be followed by Qatar, the United Arab Emirates and Saudi Arabia on Sunday and Monday. Blinken will then visit Israel and the West Bank on Tuesday and Wednesday before wrapping up the trip in Egypt.

As well as pressing Israel for dramatic increases in humanitarian aid to Gaza, a shift toward less intense military operations and a concerted effort to rein in violence against Palestinians in the occupied West Bank by Jewish settlers, Blinken will be urging reluctant Gulf Arab nations to work with the U.S. on the future of Gaza.

Hezbollah fires rockets at Israel

AP
Beirut, Jan. 6

Lebanon's Hezbollah militia fired dozens of rockets at northern Israel on Saturday, warning that the barrage was its initial response to the targeted killing, presumably by Israel, of a top leader from the allied Hamas group in Lebanon's capital earlier this week.

The rocket attack came a day after Hezbollah leader Sayyed Hassan Nasrallah said that his group must retaliate for the killing of Saleh Arouri, the deputy political leader of Hamas. Nasrallah said that if Hezbollah does not retaliate for Arouri's killing in its stronghold south of Beirut, all of Lebanon would be vulnerable to Israeli attack.

Nasrallah appeared to be making the case for a response to the Lebanese public, even at the risk of escalating the fighting between Hezbollah and Israel. But he did not indicate how or when the militants would act.

Hezbollah said Saturday that it launched 62 rockets toward an air surveillance base on Mount Meron and that it scored direct hits. The Israeli military about 40 rockets were fired toward the area of Meron but made no mention of a base. It said it struck the cell that fired the rockets.

The escalating cross-border exchanges came as U.S. Secretary of State Antony Blinken began a Middle East trip to prevent the Israel-Hamas war, now in its 14th week, from spreading across the region. Blinken was in Turkey on Saturday for meetings with the country's president and foreign minister. It's Blinken's fourth Middle East trip in three months.

International criticism of Israel's operations in Gaza has been mounting, while the U.S. is increasingly worried about the end game. This comes in addition to Washington's worries about a recent explosion in attacks in the Red Sea, Lebanon, Iran and Iraq.

JAPAN QUAKE DEATH TOLL PASSES 100

AFP
Japan, Jan. 6

Rescuers and residents sifted through rubble Saturday as focus turned to recovering bodies and cleaning up rather than finding survivors, five days after a huge earthquake struck central Japan killing at least 110 people.

The death toll from the New Year's Day 7.5-magnitude quake in the Ishikawa region of Japan's main Honshu island was certain to rise, with 210 people still unaccounted for, authorities said.

The work of thousands of rescue workers has been hampered by bad weather – snow was forecast for Sunday – and roads torn apart by gaping cracks and blocked by an estimated 1,000 landslides.

Two elderly women were pulled from the wreckage of their homes on Thursday in the badly hit city of Wajima on the Noto peninsula, but since there has been no reason for cheer.

In Suzu, where dozens of homes lie in ruins, a dog barked while an AFP team filmed the clean-up operation on Friday, the signal of a grim discovery.

"Training for disaster rescue dogs begins with something similar to a game of hide-and-seek," canine trainer Masayo Kikuchi told AFP.

"Finally they are trained to bark when seeing a person under the rubble."

Houses containing any fatalities that are discovered are being marked and left alone until a coroner can come with relatives to identify the body.

In the port city fishing boats were sunk or lifted like toys onto the shore by tsunami waves that also reportedly swept one person away.

Alaska Airlines grounds an aircraft after mid-air window blowout on flight

AP
New York, Jan. 6

Alaska Airlines grounded all of its Boeing 737-9 aircraft late Friday, hours after a window and piece of fuselage on one such plane blew out in midair and forced an emergency landing in Portland, Oregon. No one was seriously hurt.

The incident occurred shortly after take-off and the gaping hole caused the cabin to depressurize. Flight data showed the plane climbed to 16,000 feet (4,876 meters) before returning to Portland International Airport. The airline said the plane landed safely with 174 passengers and six crew members.

"Following tonight's event on Flight 1282, we have decided to take the precautionary step of temporarily grounding our fleet of 65 Boeing 737-9 aircraft." Alaska Airlines CEO Ben Minicucci said in a statement. "My heart goes out to those who were on this flight – I am so sorry for what you experienced."

Each of the aircraft will be returned to service after full maintenance and safety inspections, which Minicucci said the airline anticipated completing within days.

"We are working with Boeing and regulators to understand what occurred tonight, and will share updates as more information is available," he said.

The airline provided no immediate information about injuries. However, KPTV reported that according to the Port of Portland, the fire department responded and treated minor injuries at the scene. One person was taken for more treatment but wasn't seriously hurt.



PHOTO: AP

Alaska Airlines planes are shown parked at gates at sunrise, March 1, 2021, at Seattle-Tacoma International Airport in Seattle.

The plane was diverted about about six minutes after taking off at 5:07 p.m., according to flight tracking data from the FlightAware website. It landed at 5:26 p.m. The pilot told Portland air traffic controllers the plane had an emergency, was depressurized and needed to return to the airport, according to a recording made by the website LiveATC.net.

A passenger sent KATU-TV a photo showing the hole in the side of the airplane next to passenger seats. Video shared with the station showed people wearing oxygen masks and passengers clapping as the plane landed.

Myanmar confirms north-eastern city seized by ethnic alliance

AP
Bangkok, Jan. 6

Myanmar's military government has acknowledged that it withdrew its forces from a key city on the north-eastern border with China after it was taken over by an alliance of ethnic armed groups it has been battling for months.

The fall of Laukkaing late Thursday is the biggest in a series of defeats suffered by Myanmar's military government since the ethnic alliance launched an offensive Oct. 27. It underlines the pressure the government is under as it battles pro-democracy guerrillas in the wake of a 2021 military takeover as well as ethnic minority armed groups across the country.

Ethnic armed organizations have battled for greater autonomy for decades, but Myanmar has been wracked by what amounts to civil war since the army seized power in February 2021 from the elected government of Aung San Suu Kyi, sparking nationwide armed resistance by pro-democracy forces.

The Three Brotherhood Alliance that took Laukkaing is composed of the Myanmar National Democratic Alliance Army, the Ta'ang National Liberation Army and the Arakan Army. The MNDAA is a military force of the Kokang minority, who are ethnic Chinese.

Photos and videos on social media showed a vast amount of weapons that the alliance claimed to have captured.

Laukkaing is the capital of the Kokang Self-Administered Zone, which is geographically part of northern Shan state in Myanmar.

Myanmar government spokesperson Maj. Gen. Zaw Min Tun told the Popular News Journal, a pro-army website, on Saturday that the military and its local commanders relinquished control of Laukkaing after considering many aspects, including the safety of the family members of the soldiers stationed there.

He said the military also took into consideration Myanmar's relationship with China, which is just across the border from Laukkaing. China, which has good relations with both the military and the ethnic alliance, has been seeking an end to the fighting.

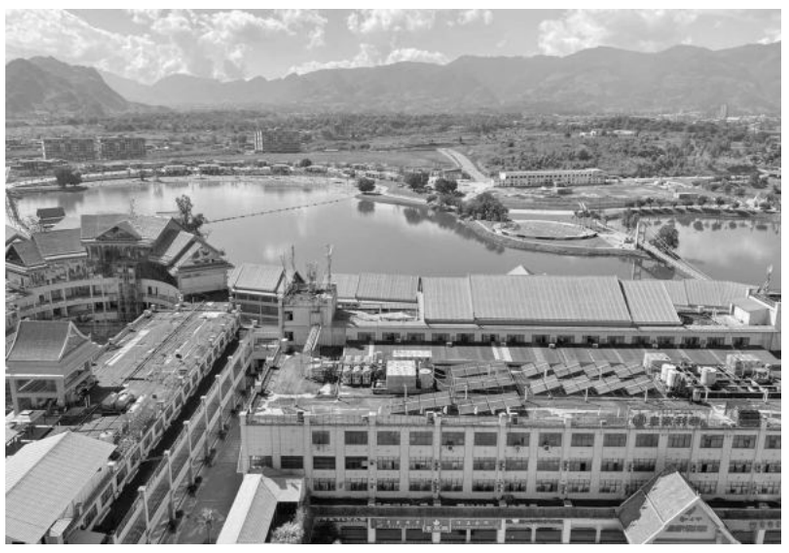


PHOTO: AP

This photo shows a view of Laukkaing city in Shan state, Myanmar, Nov. 20, 2023.

'Unjustifiable actions in Gaza by Israel'

AFP
Israel, Jan. 6

On December 26, Israel's first conscientious objector since the start of its war against Hamas, Tal Mantic, was sent to prison after refusing to serve in the army. Mitnick, however, is not alone. A small group of Israelis are refusing to take part in the "oppression of the Palestinians" by refusing to serve in the Gaza conflict. We met with some of them in Israel.

Young people refusing to serve in the Israel Defense Forces (IDF) are known as "refuseniks" in Israel. The term dates from the Soviet era and once referred to Jews denied the right to emigrate to Israel from the Soviet bloc.

Although military service in the Jewish state is compulsory for both men and women – with many seeing it as an important part of their national identity – the refuseniks are increasingly speaking out.

"On February 25th (my enlistment date) ... I will refuse to enlist and go to military jail for it," Sofia Orr, an 18-year-old Israeli woman, told AFP in the Pardes Hanna-Karkur municipality of the Haifa district.

"I refuse to take part in the violent policies of oppression and apartheid that Israel enacted upon the Palestinian people, and especially now with the war," Orr said in English. "I want to fight to convey the message that there is no military solution to a political problem, and that is more apparent than ever now. And I want to be part of the solution and not the problem."

Orr's words echo those of her friend Tal Mitnick, the jailed 18-year-old who was sentenced on January 2 to 30 days in prison by a military court.

In a statement published on social media before his incarceration, Mitnick said that a lasting solution will not come from the army. "Violence cannot solve the situation – neither by Hamas, nor by Israel. There is no military solution to a political problem. Therefore, I refuse to enlist in an army that believes that the real problem can be ignored, under a government that only continues the bereavement and pain."

"I'm very proud of him (Mitnick) and also inspired by his courage," Orr said.



PHOTO: AFP

Sofia Orr is 18 years old and will refuse to do Israel's obligatory military service on February 25, 2024.

"Everyone has different beliefs. But in the general sense, yes, I absolutely stand behind his open letter and behind his stand."

She said the political situation in Israel has made it harder than ever to conscientiously object. "Right now, it's more difficult than ever to refuse and to take this stand, because the political environment in Israel has gotten way tougher since the war started. There has been a strong shift to the right, and the entire political sphere has become a lot more violent and aggressive," Orr said.

The Israeli army relies almost exclusively on reservists. Men are required to enlist for 32 months and women for 24, after which they can be mobilised until their 40th and 38th birthdays, respectively.

Following Hamas's surprise attacks on October 7 that left more than 1,100 Israelis dead, the army mobilised more than 360,000 reservists, about 4 percent of the country's population of 9.8 million, representing Israel's largest mobilisation since the 1973 Yom Kippur War.

'A politically motivated decision'

Orr, who describes herself as an "activist" and a "political person", said it was already clear to her that she would conscientiously object at the age of 15. And she has not wavered since.

"The 7th of October changed nothing in either direction," she said. "It should have been expected, because when you put people under extreme violence, extreme violence will rise back at you. It's inevitable."

She said the attacks in southern Israel "only made me surer in my decision".

PRISM

Man runs 242 marathons in one year

Toronto: A Toronto man who ran 242 freestyle marathons -- marathon-length runs with no set course -- over the course of 2023 may have broken a world record.

Ben Pobjoy, who called his project the "Marathon Earth Challenge," traveled across North America, South America, Europe, Africa and Asia, running 26.2 miles in each location.

He ended up running a total 242 of his solo marathons in 2023 in an attempt to break the Guinness World Record for the most marathons completed in one year.

The record is currently held by U.S. man Larry Macon, who ran 239 marathons in 2012. Pobjoy said he has submitted evidence of his runs to GWR for review.

Two sloth bear cubs born

Florida: A Florida zoo announced the births of two baby sloth bears, the first members of their species to be born at the zoo since 1998.

Zoo Miami announced Friday that 4-year-old first-time mother Kematee, who came to the facility from the Philadelphia Zoo in 2021, gave birth to the first cub in a secluded area behind her public habitat at 4 a.m. on Dec. 4 and the second cub followed about 9:30 a.m.

The cubs, which are female, were fathered by 11-year-old Hank, and they also mark his first surviving cubs, the zoo announced. The sloth bears, native to the Indian subcontinent, are the first to be born at Zoo Miami since 1998.

"Kematee will remain off-exhibit, secluded in her den with the cubs, to help ensure that they are able to continue to establish a strong bond with minimal interruptions or distractions," the zoo said.

(Agencies)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1610 – Galileo Galilei makes his first observation of the four Galilean moons.
1738 – A peace treaty is signed between Peshwa Bajirao and Jai Singh II following Maratha victory in the Battle of Bhopal.
1782 – The first American commercial bank, the Bank of North America, opens.
1920 – The New York State Assembly refuses to seat five duly elected Socialist assemblymen.
1959 – The United States recognizes the new Cuban government of Fidel Castro.
1985 – Japan Aerospace Exploration Agency launches Sakigake, Japan's first interplanetary spacecraft and the first deep space probe to be launched by any country other than the United States or the Soviet Union.
2015 – Two gunmen commit mass murder at the offices of Charlie Hebdo in Paris, shooting twelve people execution style, and wounding eleven others.

NC MEET DEFERRED

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 6

Nepali Congress has rescheduled its Central Work Execution Committee meeting for Sunday.

The meeting was scheduled for Saturday earlier.

NC chief secretary Krishna Prasad Paudel informed that the meeting was rescheduled for 1.00 pm Sunday at the party central office, Senapa of Lalitpur.

The party said the meeting was postponed due to insufficient time for preparation. Party leaders remained being busy in ruling parties' coalition on Saturday affected the meeting of the NC.

The meeting is likely to pick names of candidates for the National Assembly member election.

As per the NA election scheduled candidacy, nomination is fixed for Monday.

DEATH TOLL IN ISLAMIC STATE-CLAIMED SUICIDE BLASTS RISES TO 91

AP
Tehran, Jan. 6

The death toll from a suicide bombing in Iran claimed by the Islamic State group has risen to at least 91, state TV reported Saturday.

The TV quoted Babak Yektaparast, a spokesman for the country's emergency services, as saying an 8-year boy and a 67-year-old man who were wounded in the attack have now died.

Yektaparast added that there are 102 people still being treated in hospitals, of whom 11 are in critical condition.

In Wednesday's attack, one suicide bomber detonated his explosives, then another attacked 20 minutes later as emergency workers and other people tried to help the wounded.

The attack took place in Kerman, about 820 kilometers (510 miles) southeast of the capital, Tehran. It targeted a commemoration for Guard Gen. Qassem Soleimani, killed in 2020 by a U.S. drone strike as he led its expeditionary Quds Force.

The intelligence ministry said Friday that one of the two suicide bombers was a Tajik national and 11 people linked to the attack have been arrested.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Revelers from Kirat community performing Sakela dance on the occasion of Udhauli festival at Tundikhel in Kathmandu on Saturday.

Machineries, tools worth Rs. 30 million booked in two days of Pokhara Exhibition

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Pokhara, Jan. 6

The first two days of the first province-level Agri-Machinery Exhibition 2080 being organised in Pokhara witnessed a booking of machineries and tools worth Rs. 30 million and footfall of more than 20,000 people.

Machines and tools worth Rs. 4 million have also been sold in the first two days of the expo that will run till Sunday, informed the organiser, Nepal Agricultural Machinery Entrepreneurs Association (NAMEA). The expo features more than 70 stalls of 60 companies of production, sales, maintenance, training and application of agricultural machineries and equipment.

On the second day of the exhibition, an interaction programme was organised on agricultural machineries and sustainable farming where the stakeholders emphasised on the need for the government to make a flexible policy to promote mechanisation in agriculture.

Chief of National Agricultural Engineering Research Centre Dr. Shrimat Shrestha said that the use of machines in agriculture has gone up significantly as the number of farmers using power tillers has reached 11.4 per cent from just 2 per cent a decade ago. Similarly, the number of farmers using tractors has gone up to 40 per cent from 22 per cent. However, mechanisation of agriculture is better in Tarai than the hill region.

There is a situation where a tax of 15 to 40 per cent has to be paid on the raw materials of machine production, while ready-made goods can be imported with a tax of 1 per cent, said Dr. Shrestha. He also said that lack of human resources in the field of research and development in agriculture has also adversely impacted agriculture.

Likewise, Gaurav Shrestha, Secretary of NAMEA, said that more than 95 per cent of agricultural machineries are imported from India and China. He informed that there is no clear law or provision of facilities and the businessmen are in a wait-and-see situation to operate the industry.

Ritesh Dev, Chief Mechanical Engineer of National Innovation Centre, who is currently managing the Birgunj Agricultural Inputs Factory, said that if the tools are produced according to the needs of the farmers, more jobs will be created.

"It is necessary to increase investment in innovation in the country. In addition, research and development should be prioritised institutionally," he said.

Similarly, Director General of the Department of Agriculture Dr. Hari Bahadur KC, discussions are being held on the need to bring clarity to the current provisions in matters such as imports of agricultural machines. "If there are any matters related to the customs tax on raw materials and machinery, I request you to submit them to the ministry now as we have started the work for the preparation of the budget for the next year," he said.

Under Secretary of the Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supplies of the federal government, Prakash Acharya, assured that the government would discuss further to solve the problem in the repairing of machines provided by the government. According to him, reducing the customs tax on the import of raw materials of machinery goods is not something that could happen with the wish of the Ministry of Industry. "We will take the necessary initiatives with the relevant agencies in this matter," he assured.

President of NAMEA, Krishna Sharma, urged the farmers not to buy machinery from traders who do not have a written contract and repair guarantee.

Nepali Army commences unification march from Gorkha Durbar

BY NARENDRA DHAKAL
Gorkha, Jan. 6

A contingent of Nepali Army began a unification march on Saturday. General Officer Commandant (GOC) of Nepali Army's Paschim Pritana Headquarters Major General Sanotsh Ballav Paudel and Gorkha Municipality Mayor Krishna Bahadur Rana bid farewell to the team with a torch.

Similarly, Bhimsen Thapa Rural Municipality Chairperson Lok Prasad Banjara, Gorkha Municipality Deputy Mayor Musli Maya Thokar, Gorkha's Chief District Officer Bhola Dahal and others also bid farewell to the team.

A team of soldiers with torch, national flag of Nepal, flags of five Battalions of Nepali Army (Srinath, Kalibaksh, Purano Gorakh, Bardbani and Sabuj) established during the time of Prithvinarayan Shah has set out from Gorkha Durbar.

The team consists of 10 soldiers dressed in traditional Nepali Army uniform (black cloth) and 20 soldiers in current army uniform. This is the fourth unification march organised by the Nepali Army. Gorkha Municipality and Bhimsen Rural Municipality had jointly supported the march.

Mayor Rana said, "Gorkha is a historic land associated with the glorious history of Prithvi Narayan Shah and the Nepali Army. We are proud to participate in such march and plan to develop it into a unification trail."

The Nepali Army accompanied by traditional Nepali music and the Army band that marched from Hanuman Chautara will reach Ghatbesi of Borlang via Gorkha Palace, Jorpokhari, Taple and Asrang. Lieutenant Bhuwan Thapa of Ripumardan Battalion of the Nepali Army said that the Gorkhali team would return after handing over the torch and flag to the Dhading team.

The team will receive a welcome and farewell with tea in every ward and at historical sites along their route. The process will continue through Dhading and Nuwakot to Kathmandu. Dhading will then pass the torch and flag to Nuwakot, and Nuwakot to Kathmandu's army.

The torch and flag sent from Gorkha will reach Hanuman Dhoka in Kathmandu on the evening of January 11. Later, there would be a performance with the same torch to mark the Prithvi Jayanti and National Unity Day which falls on January 12.

There is a history that national hero Prithvi Narayan Shah attacked Kathmandu via Dhading and Nuwakot during the expansion of Gorkha kingdom. The government has been promoting tourism by developing the then road as a foot trail, emphasizing the history of the Shah dynasty who built the present Nepal by unifying the scattered principalities.

Jajarkot earthquake

Over 10,000 huts built

RSS
Triveni (Rukum West), Jan 6:

Construction of temporary houses for the quake survivors is underway in Rukum Paschim. An earthquake had jolted Jajarkot and Rukum Paschim districts with its epicenter at Ramidanda of Jajarkot on November 3, 2023, destroying thousands of houses.

Two months since the disaster, most of the quake survivors are still living under tarpaulin sheets. Although 10,423 temporary houses are built across in the district in two months, number of the survivors to have such facilities is big, said acting Chief District Officer, Prabesh Baduwal.

He shared that 7,087 houses are under construction in the district. So far, 4,041 temporary huts- highest- are built in Sanibheri rural municipality while there are only 24 huts in Musikot municipality.

Baduwal mentioned that 3,014 temporary huts were built in Aathbiskot municipality, while 2,289 in Chaurjahari municipality, 938 in Tribeni rural municipality and 117 in Bafikot rural municipality.

Total Rs 590.2 million has been sent to local disaster relief fund from District Disaster Management Fund for 23,608 beneficiaries so far.

Similarly, police have collected details of 27,682 beneficiaries across the district. The District Administration Office expects that the number of beneficiaries might increase as task of collecting their details was still going on.

Police probe UK Post Office for accusing over 700 employees of theft

AP
London, Jan. 6

U.K. police have opened a fraud investigation into Britain's Post Office over a miscarriage of justice that saw hundreds of postmasters wrongfully accused of stealing money when a faulty computer system was to blame.

The Metropolitan Police force said late Friday that it is investigating "potential fraud offences arising out of these prosecutions," relating to money the Post Office received "as a result of prosecutions or civil actions" against accused postal workers.

Police also are investigating potential offenses of perjury and perverting the course of justice over investigations and prosecutions carried out by the Post Office.

Between 1999 and 2015, more than 700 post office branch managers were accused of theft or fraud because computers wrongly showed that money was missing. Many were financially ruined after being forced to pay large sums to the company, and some were convicted and sent to prison. Several killed themselves.

The real culprit was a defective computer accounting system called Horizon, supplied by the Japanese technology firm Fujitsu, that was installed in local Post Office branches in 1999.

The Post Office maintained for years that data from Horizon was reliable and accused branch managers of dishonesty when the system showed money was missing.

After years of campaigning by victims and their lawyers, the Court of Appeal quashed 39 of the convictions in 2021. A judge said the Post Office "knew there were serious issues about the reliability" of Horizon and had committed "egregious" failures of investigation and disclosure.

A total of 93 of the postal workers have now had their convictions overturned, according to the Post Office. But many others have yet to be exonerated, and only 30 have agreed to "full and final" compensation payments.

Thousands in Islamabad attend funeral for Pakistani cleric

AP
Islamabad, Jan. 6

Thousands of mourners attended a funeral Saturday for a Pakistani Sunni Muslim cleric gunned down in broad daylight on the outskirts of the capital, Islamabad, police and a spokesman for the cleric's organization said.

The funeral of Masoodur Rehman Usmani was held a day after unidentified gunmen shot and killed him and wounded his driver in the neighborhood of Ghauri Town, according to a statement from Islamabad police.

No one claimed responsibility for the attack, which is a rare occurrence in this part of Pakistan. Police said they were using closed-circuit TV footage to track down the assailants, and vowed that they would be arrested and brought to justice.

Authorities in Islamabad have stepped up security by deploying additional police and some embassies were advising their nationals to avoid visiting the area where the funeral for Usmani was to be held.



PHOTO: AP

People attend the funeral of Pakistani Sunni Muslim cleric Masoodur Rehman Usmani in Islamabad, Pakistan, Saturday, Jan. 6.

Usmani was a deputy secretary at the Sunni Ulema Council, which emerged after Pakistan outlawed the Sipah-e-Sahaba extremist group, which has been accused of killing thousands of Shiites in recent decades across the country.

Sunni clerics in their speeches at the funeral asked the government to ensure the arrest of those responsible for Usmani's killing. Top cleric Ahmed Ludhianvi threatened a sit-in in Islamabad if they were not arrested within the week.

The funeral was livestreamed on social media by organizers, who wanted to hold the event outside parliament. But police refused their request, and the event was instead held in a busy commercial area in Islamabad.

Pakistan has suffered frequent sectarian violence between the majority Sunni and minority Shiite groups, but authorities say it is still unclear who was behind the killing, although mourners were seen chanting slogans against Shiites and neighboring Iran, which is often accused by Sunni groups of backing Shiite organizations in Pakistan.

Most Sunnis and Shiites live together peacefully in Pakistan, though tensions have existed for decades.

Overdependence on remittance not in long-term interest....

service sector has been increasing year after year. In the fiscal year 2022/23, the ratio of remittance to the gross domestic product stood at 22.70 per cent.

But the overall service sector has not been able to cover the trade deficit.

It seems that adequate efforts have been made by the government of Nepal through the five-year plan, annual budget and various policy arrangements to ensure that the remittances can be invested in the productive sector and help to achieve sustainable economic development by creating more jobs.

Similarly, with the aim of encouraging the migrant workers to send remittances through formal means, the central bank has also made a policy arrangement to maintain an interest rate that is at least one percentage point higher than the interest rate published by banks and financial institutions on deposits received from remittances.

But because of the heavy reliance on remittances in the management of the external sector, even modest fluctuations in remittance flows could leave a major impact on various sectors of the economy.

The remittance has contributed significantly to meeting basic needs, reducing poverty, increasing the literacy rate, and building and developing infrastructure in the fields of agriculture, tourism, energy and sports.

Similarly, it seems that Nepal has created a comfortable environment to keep the economy running even during various crises such as conflicts, blockades, earthquakes and floods.

"There is no need to be happier seeing the increase in remittance. It is unfortunate to depend only on remittances for more than two decades, failing to create employment opportunities and expand domestic production," said Khanal.

"If we delay further to retain youth in the country and mobilise them in production, the country's economy cannot improve and it will fall in crisis anytime when the remittance drops for any reason," he said. Khanal said, "The remittance is not a long-term source for national economic consolidation. But, it is essential to properly use the remittance received from migrant workers for the foundation of the national economy through investing it in the productive sector," he said.

Definitely, when there is an increase in remittance, the consumption of families who send money from abroad will increase in the country, he said, and added consumption boost helps the economy grow. Now, import has dropped even though consumption has increased, which is a positive sign for our economy, he said.

According to him, the government should focus on investing remittance in the productive sector, including agriculture, hydropower and tourism, without delay instead of being happy seeing the increment in remittance inflow, which will contribute to the economy for the short term.

NRB information officer Dr. Pokhrel said that it was necessary to look for alternative to remittance to reduce the dependence on remittance as the inflow of remittance might be affected any time when our labour destination countries stop hiring workers.

Migrant workers increase

Lately, the number of people going abroad for foreign employment has also increased.

According to the Department of Foreign Employment, about 277,000 people went abroad during the first five months of the current fiscal year 2023/24.

Kabiraj Upreti, information officer of the Department of Foreign Employment, said that the number of people going for foreign employment has increased this year compared to the pre-COVID-19 time.

Around 71,000 people went abroad for jobs within a single month of Mangsir of the current fiscal year.

He said that although the number of people going to work abroad had decreased after the COVID-19 pandemic, it has started increasing since last year. The United Arab Emirates (UAE), Saudi Arabia, Qatar and Malaysia are the major labour destinations of Nepalis.

According to the Department, the number of people who took labour permits from Nepal in the fiscal year 2022/23 increased by 22.42 per cent compared to the fiscal year 2021/22 and reached 771,327.

The businessmen also admitted that lack of investment environment and weak investment confidence of domestic and foreign investors in Nepal has been affecting job creation in the country.

Breach of...

A wider white-coloured marking has been made for vehicles heading towards the Naya Baneshwor Chowk from the Sankhamul side to restrict them from encroaching the lane for opposite traffic.

"Be it a divider, metal rod or only coloured marking, they are all a means to prevent traffic congestion and collisions with vehicles heading from the opposite direction. If everyone remained in their lanes, it would prevent traffic jams and accidents," said a traffic police officer as he monitored vehicles at the Naya Baneshwor Chowk.

Similarly, when the officers were asked whether the violators of lane discipline in the intersection were penalised, they argued that it would only backfire as always. "If we started penalising every vehicle that violated lane rule in the Naya Baneshwor intersection, we would run out of tickets in a day," another officer said.

Ten Creative Releases Of 2023

BY MANNU SHAHI



With 2023 over, we mark the third year-end since we started using this space to celebrate the brilliance illustrated by independent artists in the Nepali music scene. Across genres, genders, ages and industries, the list prompts from the acts raising the creative bar whilst pursuing their relentless drive with or without external validations.

In introspect, this third edition seems to reinforce a slight change in the analysing ritual with my maturing appetite for refined catchy-melodic compositions. As someone who is always drawn towards complex oeuvres, distinct timbres and eccentric structures; this year my abated liberation gathered a plethora of songs from these incredibly exalting musicians, which made this task of finalizing just ten publications from the entire year more draining than ever.

However, these hand-picked ten tunes secured their positions because of their significant musical ventures, ethical artistry and their palatable creative brands. Although generally, this column is dedicated towards encouraging rather isolated yet potent releases in a laid-back music-consuming culture like that of Nepal. This piece specifically enhances this admiration further and exclaims these creators for forging in this less-rewarding path just out of their sheer love for manifesting idiosyncratic music.

Obviously, I am also not entitling this list as the "best representation" of music publications this annum, but rather as my personal selection venerating the most ingenious musical ventures. And without further ado, here is my list of ten creative releases of 2023 in an alphabetical order:

Brihat Pahari - Bihibar

Amidst these ten songs which were a bit hard to finalize, two singles clicked for me from the very first listen: Jhuma Limbu's 'Bauju' and this stellar-tune 'Bihibar'. Premiered on December 2, 2023, the main guitar riff enamored my heart right away and 'Bihibar' with its progressive-indie-folk sound effortlessly lured its way into my playlist. Composed, arranged, recorded and produced by Brihat Pahari in his home studio - Paintbox Studios; the song features Shaurav Bhattarai as the co-lyricist and Chhitij KC on drums. An amalgamation of outstanding lyrics writing, great guitar works, impressive production and arrangement skills, the tune parades the new Nepali sound and leaves us wanting for more from this promising visionary.

Chepang - Bid

The US-based Nepali immigrindcore collective Chepang released their critically acclaimed 29-tracks LP "Swatta" on July 7, 2023. A conceptual album based on the Japanese concept 'Ikagai', a state of wellbeing that arises with devotion to activities that one enjoys and gains a sense of fulfillment from. The 11th number from the album, 'Bid' is my favorite for its complex rhythmic explorations, sturdy riffs and demonic overtones. This instrumental piece set in a progressive structure experiment with various melodic frequencies to emit an inventive and dynamic sonic palate. The LP in Bandcamp, a streaming platform, alone has sold nearly 250 copies (which rarely happens to Nepali musicians) impressing a range of heavy music enthusiasts on a global scale.

Jhuma Limbu - Bauju

Released on June 30, 2023, 'Bauju' is a tune based on the Deuda melody of far-western Nepal, the song is curated by Dikra Badi; music produced and arranged by Ganga Thapa; additional melodic contributions by Jhuma Limbu; lyrics by Harka Saud and Hemant Biswas. This melodic collaboration is a quintessential execution of Nepali folk fused with world music elements. The song exudes a formidable impression from the very start and does not disappoint as the plot transpires. Furthermore, 'Bauju' features instrumentalists Anudwatt Dhakal (bass), Shambhu Baniya and Sundar Kumar Maharjan (percussion), Veecheet Dhakal (violin), Manice Gandharba (sarangi) and Bishwo Shahi (mix/ master). The groovy bass foundation, desert rock inspired guitar solos and counterpoints, the fiddle ornamentations, massive percussive works are my top highlights from the tune.

John Chamling Rai - Farkanna Hola

The most commercial release in the list is this serenading single 'Farkanna Hola' by John Chamling Rai published on October 13, 2023. The soulful singer comprehends this innate songwriting ability capable of resonating to colossal masses. Throughout the song, lyrical references from his influence Bartika Eam Rai can be traced, yet the melodic brilliance and the structural elaboration in the composition creates a firm contrast. Featuring Tunna Bell Thapa on arrangement and audio production, Bishal Chhetri on acoustic guitars and Manish Gandharva on sarangi. This tune makes the list for its effortless catchy potential, as without intense embellishments the message is well-expressed and genuinely assimilated.

OutControlJoys - These Wavves

OutControlJoys are a shoegaze/ dream pop trio comprising of Sareena Rai on bass, Samn Gurung on guitars/ vocals and Prashant Bajracharya on drums. The group released their 6-tracks sophomore EP: "Unturn" on January 9, 2023 via Bandcamp; written, recorded and produced by the band themselves. The fifth song in the collection, 'These Wavves' yields the most relaxing and laid-back feeling in my opinion. Deriving the treasure in minimal spontaneous structures, this ambient listen embraces the audience in a cozy nestle radiating feelings of hope and optimism. The melancholic album ventilates emotions of failure, hopelessness and the will to oppose these notions by sentiments of love, nostalgia and joy.

Rachana Dahal - Hey Bhagwan

Rachana Dahal is undoubtedly one of the finest songwriters and most vulnerable performers of the country. Every facet of the songstress including her vision, her poignant songwriting, emotional articulation and eccentric musical ventures confirm her stance further as this unique musical phenomenon blessing the Nepali music scene with her presence. 'Hey Bhagwan' officially released on August 25, 2023 via her YouTube handle is just the correct example demonstrating the singer's intricate writing caliber and musicality. This impactful arrangement elevating the entire composition is fabricated, recorded and produced by long-time collaborator Firoj Bajracharya (Jyoti Records). Although most of her songs are just as brilliant, but 'Hey Bhagwan' in particular possesses this astounding characteristic that is a rare find in this superficial realm. Lyrically, this somber art-pop tune dwells in the dark corners of one's thought-patterns whilst simultaneously critiquing the absurdness of some universal ideologies.

Rajesh Nepali - Paramour

'Paramour' is the fifth track from Rajesh Nepali's debut album "Echo House" that was published via his YouTube channel on June 1, 2023. Composed, arranged, produced and recorded by Rajesh Nepali, the song is mixed and mastered by Thajville. After years of hustling as an independent creator and publishing multiple singles and collaborative work, the singer mustered some of his older publications and new compositions together and produced this ingenious masterpiece. The entire album justifies his protean singing ability and also his finesse in music arrangement and multi-instrumentation. 'Paramour' lyrically is dealing with the notions of mortality and the anxiety surrounding life's impermanence. Loved the piano and bass works, layered vocal harmonies, the steady beat and the outstanding virtual lute section arriving mid-way through the song.

R.O.T.I. – 436 (live)

Revenge Of The Invisibles (R.O.T.I.) is a progressive experimental quartet comprising Bikash (Rahu) Rana on vocals and guitars, Deepak Shakya on bass, Girish Shrestha on guitars and Sarin Bajracharya on drums. Encapsulating the true essence of an underground project from every aspect, R.O.T.I. hardly releases their music in the digital platforms and chooses to root their creativity in the humble settings of their jam room and live shows. However, this year Svana Studio Session Season 3 in their attempt to uplift the underground scene, convinced the supergroup to partake in their live sessions. And the result is this vigorous take of live music unlike any other Nepali modern sound among which the initial song '436' engrosses my attention the most during each listen. Premiering on February 25, 2023, the arduous melodic structure, the odd-metric pulse, the transcending guitar works, the well-executed breaks all work in favor to create this prog-rock/ rap metal influenced tune a significant composition.

Strangle - Sab Jhuto

From their self-titled third album, 'Sab Jhuto' was officially published on December 30, 2023 via Strangle's YouTube channel. A sludgy punk tune that well exhibits odd meter and complementing rhythmic subdivisions, this song stood out the most for me from their 8-tracks collection. Strangle are a hardcore quartet based in Lalitpur, devoted towards refining their musicianship and self-expression through angry loud music for over a decade. The tune exhibits the acute prowess of all four band members: Ashish Kayastha (guitars), Dipesh Joshi (drums), Bibek Tamang (bass) and Santosh Shrestha (vocals). The slower instrumental first-half gradually escalates to a faster mid-section and descends back to the sludgy feel as the vocal arrives creating an intense arc that makes the tune a remarkable accomplishment.

The Phoenix Mob - Andaaz

Honestly, I stumbled upon The Phoenix Mob only while curating this list and the group instantly caught my attention with their appealing music. Their debut EP "Rising Through The Ashes" released via Skathi Records official YouTube handle surfaced the digital realms on September 4, 2023. Produced, mixed and mastered by Ktm Souljah, the 7-tracks extended play is a propitious endeavor. 'Andaaz' is the final track from the album and the most intriguing one in my opinion for its fast-paced verses, aggressive enunciation, spooky arrangement and flattering outro decline. The group comprises six members: Rage, Nemesis, Error, Ofake, 666 and Rome; being the largest hip-hop outfit to exist in a Nepali context.



PHOTO: SAGAR BASNET/TRN

A model presenting student-designed dresses at the 'Dress to Impress' fashion show organised by the International Institute of Fashion Technology (IIFT).

Nigel Lythgoe stepping aside

AP
Los Angeles, Jan. 6



TV producer Nigel Lythgoe said Friday that he is stepping aside as a judge on "So You Think You Can Dance" after lawsuits accusing him of sexual assault, including one from Paula Abdul.

Lythgoe is also co-creator and executive producer of the Fox dance competition series, whose 18th season is set to start in March.

"I have informed the producers of 'So You Think You Can Dance' of my decision to step back from participating in this year's series," Lythgoe said in a statement. "I did so with a heavy heart but entirely voluntarily because this great program has always been about dance and dancers, and that's where its focus needs to remain. In the meantime, I am dedicating myself to clearing my name and restoring my reputation."

The 74-year-old English-born Lythgoe has been a prominent TV producer for decades in both the U.K. and the U.S., working on reality competition shows including "American Idol."

The singer and dancer Abdul alleged in a lawsuit filed Dec. 30 that Lythgoe twice assaulted her — first in the early 2000s when she was an "American Idol" judge and again about a decade later when she was a judge on "So You Think You Can Dance," which she left after two seasons.

Lythgoe called the allegations an "appalling smear" that he intends to fight.

The Associated Press does not generally identify people who say they are the victims of sexual assault unless they come forward publicly, as Abdul has done.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: At any moment, your intuition may lead you to a change that you've been wanting to make for a while. You might have thought that this shift was too drastic or risky.

CANCER: Your intuition can lead you to a more spiritual place. Today is likely to bring options like yoga classes, creative tutoring, or meditation in nature -- whatever leads you to feel connected to your sensual and soulful side.

LIBRA: You're ready to create more for yourself. You may have been relying on others lately -- it's time to make sure that you know what you want instead of letting them direct every move.

CAPRICORN: Friendship revelations could be around every corner! It might be that someone shares information about themselves that you never once suspected, and this may change the way that you think about them.

TAURUS: The deep emotions of others in your life could currently seem much more accessible. Perhaps they're approaching you for comfort and advice, they may not have done so in the past.

LEO: You're leaving the past in the past! There may be past events that have been plaguing your mind recently, certain arguments or disappointments from way back when that you're unable to stop thinking about.

SCORPIO: Self-reflection encourages healing at this time. You're possibly projecting onto others or pointing the finger at those who have disappointed you in order to make your struggles make sense to you.

AQUARIUS: Elders in your life have valuable wisdom to share at this time. It could be that your grandparents or other older folk you know don't normally share this much with you.

GEMINI: You might be shaking up your routine. Where you were once unfocused and less driven, you're presently picking up inspiration to make your routine more fun, efficient.

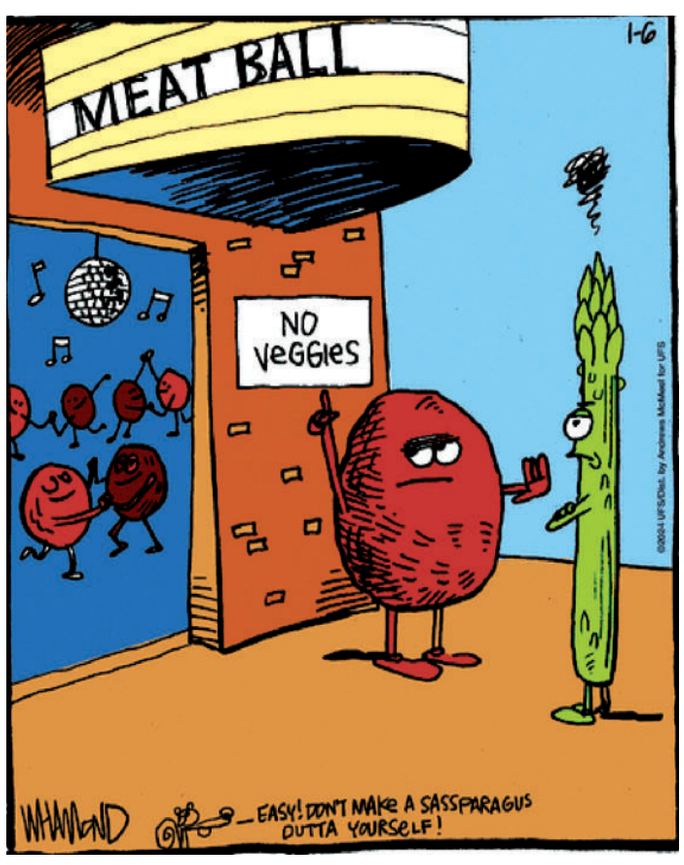
VIRGO: Wisdom can be found through the people in your life. These are most likely to be siblings, cousins, and others who have supported you in the past. You should already be able to trust their intentions.

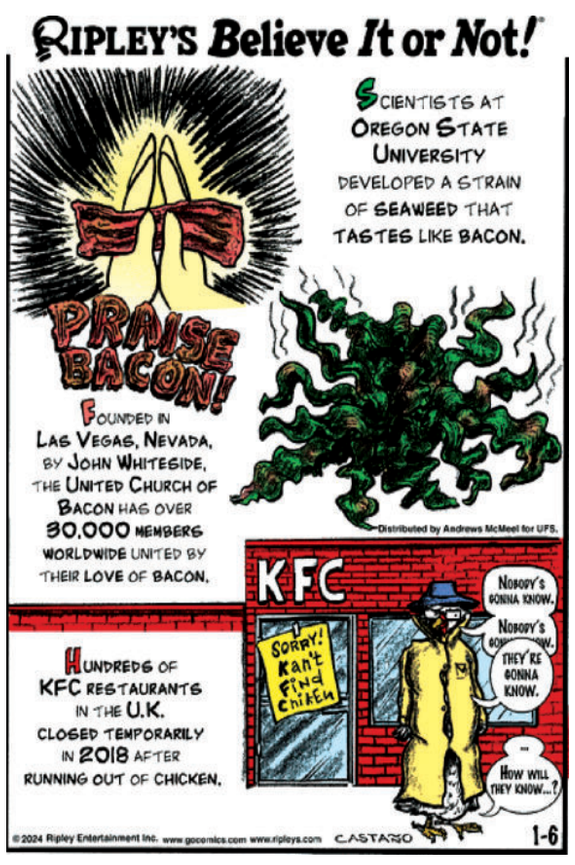
SAGITTARIUS: Your intuition might be the best guide that you have today. Following your heart takes on renewed importance, as you may only have your gut feeling to lead you through a negative situation.

PISCES: It may be time to break out on your own. You might not realise how much you've been holding back until you see someone else putting out creative projects or taking on challenges that you've wanted to handle.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Nepal to be ready while facing better teams at T20 World Cup group stage

BY NAYAK PAUDEL
Kathmandu, Jan. 6



In November 2023, in front of the home crowd, Nepal secured the ticket to the ICC Men's T20 World Cup by beating the United Arab Emirates at Mulpani International Cricket Ground.

Since then, it was certain that the men's national team was travelling to the United States of America (USA) and West Indies, joint hosts for the 2024 World Cup, in June 2024; however, Nepal's cricket fraternity had to wait until Friday night to know who the opponents in the group stages were.

According to the fixtures released by the International Cricket Council (ICC), there will be four groups of five teams each competing in group matches starting from June 1. Nepal is in Group D with South Africa, the Netherlands and two South Asian countries – Bangladesh and Sri Lanka. Similarly, India, Pakistan, Ireland and the USA are in Group A, and England, Australia, Namibia, Scotland and Oman.

Uganda and Papua New Guinea are in Group C with New Zealand and the West Indies. Sri Lanka and Bangladesh are the top eighth and ninth teams in the Men's T20I Team Rankings by the ICC. While South Africa is in the sixth position, the Netherlands is one position above Nepal at 15.

Participating in the T20 World Cup after nine years, Nepal will play its first match of this campaign against the Netherlands in Dallas, USA. After playing the second match against Sri Lanka in Florida, Nepal will travel to the Caribbean and face South Africa and Bangladesh on June 14 and 16 in St. Vincent respectively. In the largest ever cricket World Cup of any format with 20 teams, including nine associates, Nepal will look forward to winning as many matches as they can.

Bangladesh has recently shown its commitment to play good cricket as it faced New Zealand in Test, T20 and ODI series. The challenge faced by India during its clash against South Africa in a series of T20, ODI and Test matches that ended on January 4 shows how great a challenge will South Africa be for Nepal. Sri Lanka has also started a 3 ODI and 3 T20I series against Zimbabwe on Saturday.

Meanwhile, despite being ranked above, four opponents of Nepal in Group D will not be seeing Nepal as an easy challenge. After giving quality competition to India and Pakistan in the Asia Cup 2023, Nepal's team has shown its abilities to the world. The T20 World Cup will be another place to shine for Nepal as it competes against four higher-ranking teams. According to the Cricket Association of Nepal (CAN), the team will be prepared for the World Cup.

As per the calendar issued by CAN on January 4, Nepal is hosting Namibia and the Netherlands for a tri-nation T20 series from February 27 to March 5.

Nepal will then fly to Hong Kong for a quadrangular T20 tournament. Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and Afghanistan are sending their A teams to Nepal for a T20 tournament from March 20 to April 5.

With several tournaments for Nepal's U19 and A team, which is said to be under formation, as well, a properly selected team is said to leave for the USA and West Indies in May 2024. The team will be participating in a high-performance camp during its stay at the host countries before the tournament kicks off, CAN informed.

David Warner goes out swinging as Australia sweep Pakistan series

AFP
Sydney, Jan. 6

Playing in his 112th and final Test, David Warner was dismissed for 57 – just 11 runs from finishing off the job – and left the Sydney Cricket Ground arena before an adoring home crowd.

Marnus Labuschagne with his 19th Test half-century on 62 and Steve Smith on four were there at the end as the Australians reached the 130-run target for the loss of just two wickets.

"We are in the entertainment business, happy to come out here and showcase what I try to do all the time," said the 37-year-old opener Warner, who made his Test debut in 2011.

"I started with Twenty20, tried to come here and emulate that, tried to play my shots and managed to get a win on the board."

Asked how he wished to be remembered, Warner added: "Exciting, entertaining and, I hope, I put a smile on everyone's face the way I played."

It was something of an anti-climax when Warner, known as "The Bull", was out after losing a review for lbw to spinner Sajid Khan.

Warner was congratulated by the Pakistan players, who had given him a guard of honour as he came out for his final innings before he waved his bat acknowledging the cheering crowd as he left the SCG for the last time.

It was a typically aggressive innings from Warner coming off 75 balls with seven fours, replete with crashing drives and audacious reverse sweeps.

It was Australia's 17th consecutive Test win against Pakistan after securing the current series in Melbourne over Christmas.

Australia had an early setback when Warner's childhood friend and fellow opener Usman Khawaja was out in the second over, lbw to Sajid for a duck.

But it set centre stage for Warner as he sought to put pressure on the bowlers and fielders with his intimidating gung-ho approach. His 37th Test half-century came off just 56 balls.

Warner retires as one of Australia's greatest opening batsmen, scoring 8,786 Test runs since his debut at an average of 44.59, with 26 centuries.

But he will also be remembered for his central role in the "Sandpapergate" ball-tampering scandal of 2018.

Impressive Jamal

Aamer Jamal was announced as the player of the match for his all-round performance of 82 in the first innings and 6-69 in Australia's first innings.

"It's been so long to get here (his Test debut)," Jamal said.

Mohammad Rizwan and Jamal had defied the Australian attack for almost the first hour of the fourth day, adding 41 runs to the overnight score before Nathan Lyon struck. Jamal followed three balls later in Cummins' next over, top-edging a pull shot straight to Travis Head at deep backward square leg for 18.

Lyon finished with three for 36 and has 509 Test wickets.



PHOTO: AUSTRALIAN CRICKET TEAM
David Warner celebrates his half-century in his final Test at the Sydney Cricket Ground.

PM CUP 2024 FIXTURES RELEASED, FINALS BECKON TOP TWO TEAMS

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 6

Fixtures for the league matches of 10 teams, including three departmental and seven provincial teams, for the PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament 2024 have been made public.

The tournament is being held in three different stadiums, including one outside the Kathmandu Valley. Tribhuvan University (TU) International Cricket Ground, Mulpani International Cricket Ground and Bhairahawa Cricket Ground are hosting the competition.

The league matches between seven provincial teams – Koshi, Madhes, Bagmati, Gandaki, Lumbini, Sudur Pashchim and Karnali – and three departmental teams – Nepal Police Club, Nepal APF Club and Tribhuwan Army Club – will start on January 13.

The championship has not yet been won by any provincial team.

Three matches have been scheduled on the opening day in the three stadiums. Bagmati is facing Nepal Police at TU Cricket Ground while Koshi and Madhes will play at Mulpani Cricket Ground. Bhairahawa Cricket Ground will be hosting Lumbini and Gandaki.

As per the fixtures, 11 league matches will be played at Bhairahawa Cricket Ground. TU Cricket Ground will also be hosting the final match of the tournament.

"We have increased the number of domestic tournaments to promote cricket at provincial and local levels. Local cricket grounds outside the Valley have been prioritised for this purpose. Several matches of the upcoming PM Men's Cup will be held in Bhairahawa as a major initiation," said Paras Khadka, secretary at CAN and a former Nepali cricket team captain.

As per the format of the tournament, the first two teams in the league table after playing nine matches each will be competing in the finals for the trophy on February 3.

Spectacular goals help Spurs and Fulham, Brentford draws with Wolves at FA Cup

AP
London, Jan. 6

Tottenham and Fulham won through to the fourth round of the FA Cup while fellow English Premier League sides Brentford and Wolves will endure a replay after they drew 1-1 on Friday.

Spurs beat Burnley 1-0 with a late goal from Pedro Porro, while Fulham overcame Rotherham 1-0 with a first-half strike from Bobby De Cordova-Reid. In London, Wolves played almost the entire match with 10 men but came from behind to earn a replay against Brentford.

Spurs hasn't won the FA Cup since 1991 and it made heavy work of a home tie against a side second to last in the league. Although Ange Postecoglou's team was on top throughout, Burnley defended stoutly and it wasn't until the 78th minute that Porro got the breakthrough.

His shot from 25 meters out was a worthy match-winner and one of several spectacular strikes in the three games.

Only five league places separate Wolves and Brentford so, on paper, their fixture was one of the most evenly matched.



PHOTO: AP
Brentford's Neal Maupay celebrates scoring his side's first goal against Wolverhampton Wanderers, in London, Jan. 5, 2024.

Brentford gained the momentum after just nine minutes when João Gomes was sent off for a bad foul. It took the lead shortly before halftime when Neal Maupay controlled a loose ball in the penalty box and fired home.

Although Brentford dominated in terms of possession and shots on goal, Wolves never looked beaten and it drew level 19 minutes into the second period when Tommy Doyle's screamer gave Brentford goalkeeper Thomas Strakosha no chance.

Fulham dispatched struggling Rotherham more easily than the one goal suggested. Rotherham lies at the bottom of the second-tier Championship with just one win in its last 14 games, and it came unstuck after 24 minutes when it lost possession while trying to play the ball out from the back.

De Cordova-Reid lashed an unstoppable drive into the top corner from 20 meters out.

Rotherham goalkeeper Viktor Johansson saved his side from a worse fate.

On Saturday, cup-holder Manchester City is at home to Huddersfield, and Sunderland takes on northeastern rival Newcastle. Arsenal hosts Liverpool in the round's glamour tie 24 hours later.

'Bit scared Nadal' suffers injury worry before Australian Open

AFP
Brisbane, Jan. 6

Rafael Nadal, a 22-time Grand Slam title winner, needed a medical time-out towards the end of his quarter-final loss at the Brisbane International, his first tournament for almost a year.

Nadal required treatment at 1-4 down in the third set of his match against Australian Jordan Thompson after feeling pain in his upper left thigh. Thompson won the match 5-7, 7-6 (8/6), 6-3 in a marathon of 3hr 25min.

Nadal squandered three match points in the second set before his latest injury woe cast a shadow over his plans for the Australian Open which gets underway in Melbourne on January 14.

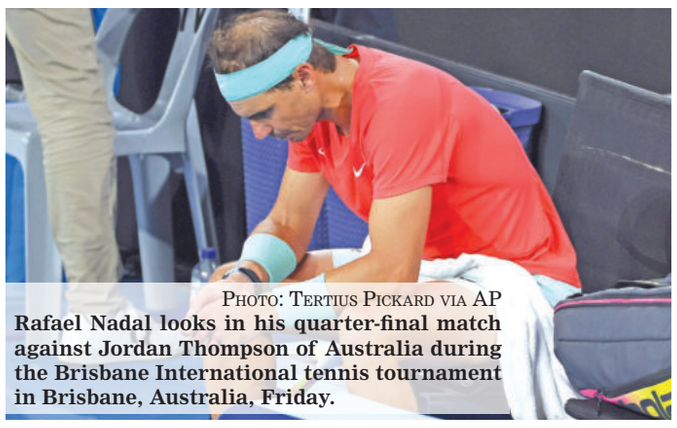


PHOTO: TERTIUS PICKARD VIA AP
Rafael Nadal looks in his quarter-final match against Jordan Thompson of Australia during the Brisbane International tennis tournament in Brisbane, Australia, Friday.

Nadal said he had played pain-free during his opening two rounds this week, but conceded he had been in pain towards the end of the quarter-final. He said that while the pain was in a similar place to last year's injury, the injury itself felt different.

"It is a very similar place to what happened last year, but different, no?" the 37-year-old said.

"I feel it's more muscle. Last year it was tendon. For sure it is not the same as last year at all because when it happened last year, I felt something drastic immediately.

"Today I didn't feel anything. The only problem is because the place is the same, you are a little bit more scared than usual.

"Hopefully it's a charged muscle and in the next days I'll make some more tests. If it's only a charged muscle it's been a very positive week," he wrote on Instagram. He ended his message with "#brisbanetennis next Melbourne".

WEATHER

Sunday

Sunrise at 6:56 am, Sunset at 5:24 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Sunday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly regions of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province, Gandaki Province, Lumbini Province and Karnali Province and mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 15 - 17°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Saturday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	16.7	2.7	0.0
Dipayal	23.0	2.8	0.0
Dhangadi	21.0	10.2	0.0
Birendranagar	21.3	6.5	0.0
Nepalgunj	20.0	11.5	0.0
Jumla	14.3	-5.7	0.0
Ghorahi	21.0	7.5	0.0
Pokhara	20.8	9.5	0.0
Bhairahawa	22.2	11.0	0.0
Simara	23.3	10.5	0.0
Kathmandu	17.5	4.5	0.0
Okhaldhunga	17.6	6.8	0.0
Taplejung	16.2	5.0	0.0
Dhankuta	23.1	8.5	0.0
Biratnagar	24.4	10.5	0.0
Jomsom	10.0	-5.5	0.0*
Dharan	24.8	13.0	0.0*
Lumle	15.6	5.4	0.0*
Janakpur	26.0	13.0	0.0*
Jiri	14.4	-0.2	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES
January 7, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.75	Rs. 133.35
Euro	1	Rs. 144.86	Rs. 145.51
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 167.98	Rs. 168.73
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 155.61	Rs. 156.31
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 88.64	Rs. 89.04
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 99.27	Rs. 99.72
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.70	Rs. 100.15
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.14	Rs. 9.18
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.56	Rs. 18.64
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.40	Rs. 35.56
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.41	Rs. 36.58
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.82	Rs. 3.84
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.14	Rs. 36.31
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.52	Rs. 28.65
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.07	Rs. 10.12
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.91	Rs. 12.97
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.42	Rs. 19.51
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 17.00	Rs. 17.07
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.52	Rs. 433.48
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.12	Rs. 353.71

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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